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Malachi

Malachi 1:1

Section 1:1: Introduction

This opening verse is short and introduces the whole book. It tells us that this book was a direct message from the LORD to his people, that is, a prophecy. The person through whom the LORD spoke this prophecy was the prophet Malachi.

In some languages, it may be better not to put a section heading before the first verse, since the verse itself is a sort of title. See, for example, 1:1 in NIV, GNT, NJB, REB, CEV, NCV, NLT. If that is true in your language, then the first section heading will be the one placed before 1:2.

1:1

This is the burden of the word of the LORD to Israel through Malachi:

- ¶ This is a solemn message that Yahweh spoke to the people of Israel through Malachi.
- ¶ This is an important message which Yahweh gave/revealed to me, Malachi, to speak to the people of Israel.

This is the burden of the word of the LORD: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as burden is the word *maśśaʿ*. In Scripture, it usually refers to prophetic messages or warnings of judgement. It signifies that what follows is important because it is a direct word from God, which the prophet had a strong obligation to announce.

LORD: The word LORD represents the Hebrew Yahweh, the personal name of God. In the Hebrew text, this is a proper name, not a title or general noun. See the discussion of Yahweh, the LORD in the “Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi” section of the Introduction.

to Israel through Malachi: The word Malachi means “my messenger,” but it is almost certainly used here as the personal name of the prophet. See the discussion of The author in the Introduction.

The writer introduced himself in the third person, as if he were speaking about someone else. The writers of the New Testament letters did this also. Most English versions keep the third person forms. However, if this would be confusing for your readers, you could reword it as the CEV has done:

I am Malachi. And this is the message that the Lord gave me for Israel. (CEV)

Israel: This refers to the people who were the descendants of Israel (also known as Jacob). Jacob/Israel was the son of Isaac and grandson of Abraham.

Malachi 1:2

Section 1:2–5: The LORD loved the people of Israel very much

Paragraph 1:2–5

At the time when Malachi was writing, the people of Israel were discouraged. Some years earlier their enemies, the Babylonians, had defeated them in war and had taken them as slaves to Babylon.

After some time the people of Israel had been released and were now living again in their own land, but life was very difficult. Perhaps they felt that the LORD had failed to bless them as a nation. They questioned whether the LORD really loved them. The LORD answered this accusation by pointing out that he had chosen to love them more than other nations. He told them that he had shown this love when he chose their ancestor Jacob and entered into a covenant relationship with him and his descendants (Genesis 28:13–15, 35:9–12, 46:3–4).

1:2a

“I have loved you,”

- ¶ “I have always loved you^(plur) very much.”
- ¶ “I have shown you^(plur) that I love you^(plur).”

I have loved you: This is the first of the LORD’s statements of fact.

have loved: The tense of the verb “love” used here in Hebrew is not limited to present time. It can include past time as well as a present. GNT makes this clear with:

I have always loved you. (GNT)

1:2b

says the LORD.

- These are the words of Yahweh.
- Yahweh has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh says to you^(plur).

says the LORD: The speech clause, says the LORD (or “says the LORD of Hosts”), occurs many times throughout the text. This emphasizes repeatedly that this is a direct message from the LORD. See note 1 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

Notice that in the BSB this clause occurs after the speech. This is good English style. You should place

your speech clause wherever it would naturally occur in your language.

1:2c

But you ask, “How have You loved us?”

- But you^(plur) people of Israel say, “How have you^(sing) loved us?^(excl)”
- But you^(plur) reply, “What have you^(sing) done to show us that you^(sing) love us?^(excl)”

But you ask: This phrase introduces the first of the objections made by the people of Israel. Most English versions keep the second person pronoun you. This emphasizes the personal relationship which the LORD had with his people.

How have You loved us?: This question expresses surprise and disbelief.

1:2d

“Was not Esau Jacob’s brother?” declares the LORD.

- “Esau was Jacob’s brother, was he not?” Yahweh says to you^(plur),
- Yahweh answers, “You^(plur) know that Esau was the older brother of your^(plur) ancestor Jacob,

Was not Esau Jacob’s brother?: This is a rhetorical question. The LORD was speaking again. By using the question form, the LORD emphasized a fact that the people knew well. Esau and Jacob were children of the same father and the same mother. (In fact, they were twins. See Genesis 25:21–26.)

declares the LORD: See the note on 1:2b. Notice that in the BSB this speech clause again occurs after the question. This is good English style. You should place it wherever it would naturally occur in your language.

1:2e–3a

loved...hated: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as hated needs to be understood in contrast to the word which the BSB translates as loved. In this context loved means “chosen,” “favored” (as in Deuteronomy 7:7–8; Jeremiah 31:3; Hosea 11:1), while hated is the opposite: “not chosen,” “rejected” or “set aside.” Jacob had been chosen to be the ancestor of the LORD’s special people. By choosing Jacob, the LORD, therefore, was not choosing Jacob’s twin brother, Esau.

In some languages it may be best to use words like “choose” and “reject.” For example:

yet I have accepted Jacob and have rejected Esau.
(NJPS)

yet I chose Jacob, and rejected Esau. (NET)

Jacob...Esau: This verse is not referring only to the individuals, Jacob and Esau, but also to their descendants. Jacob was the ancestor of the nation of Israel, and Esau was the ancestor of a different nation. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

²Esau and Jacob were brothers, but I have loved Jacob and his descendants, ³and have hated Esau and his descendants. (GNT)

General Comment on 1:2e–3a

In some languages it may be helpful to reverse the order of 1:2e and 1:3a. For example:

^{3a}but it was not Esau whom I chose to be the ancestor of my people. ^{2e}Instead, I chose Jacob and his descendants.

1:2e

“Yet Jacob I have loved,

- “but I loved Jacob and chose him and his descendants to be my people

Malachi 1:3

Section 1:2–5: The LORD loved the people of Israel very much

Paragraph 1:2–5

At the time when Malachi was writing, the people of Israel were discouraged. Some years earlier their enemies, the Babylonians, had defeated them in war and had taken them as slaves to Babylon.

After some time the people of Israel had been released and were now living again in their own land, but life was very difficult. Perhaps they felt that the LORD had failed to bless them as a nation. They questioned whether the LORD really loved them. The LORD answered this accusation by pointing out that he had chosen to love them more than other nations. He told them that he had shown this love when he chose their ancestor Jacob and entered into a covenant relationship with him and his descendants (Genesis 28:13–15, 35:9–12, 46:3–4).

1:3a

but Esau I have hated,

- while I rejected Esau and his descendants.

1:3b

and I have made his mountains a wasteland

- See how I have made the hill country where the descendants/people of Esau used to live an empty wasteland?
- I have made the hill country of Esau's descendants barren and deserted.

made...a wasteland: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as made...a wasteland literally means “made a waste.” This means that the LORD made the land barren and deserted. Some ways to say this are: About six hundred years before the birth of Christ, the Nabatean Arabs gradually took over the land of Edom, driving the Edomites from the area. (Nabaioth, the ancestor of the Nabateans, was the eldest son of Ishmael and therefore grandson of Abraham (Genesis 25:12–13).) This had already happened by the time that Malachi was writing.

I turned Esau's hill country into a barren desert.
(CEV)

I turned Esau's mountains into a deserted wasteland.
(NET)

his mountains: Esau had already been dead many years before Malachi received this prophecy. The expression which the BSB translates as his mountains refers to the hilly region where Esau's descendants lived.

1:3c
and left his inheritance to the desert jackals.”

- I have left that desert land to jackals as their home.”
- So that region now belongs to the wild animals.”

inheritance: This refers to the land of Edom, that is, the land where Esau and his descendants had formerly lived. The LORD had given them that land, but later he had taken it from them because of what they had done to the people of Israel. The Edomites consistently opposed the Israelites on many occasions through history. In 589–587 BC they joined with the Babylonians to fight against the people of Judah, and to destroy Jerusalem. (See the book of Obadiah, especially verses 10–14.) About six hundred years before the birth of Christ, the Nabatean Arabs gradually took over the land of Edom, driving the Edomites from the area. (Nabaioth, the ancestor of the Nabateans, was the eldest son of Ishmael and therefore grandson of Abraham (Genesis 25:12–13).) This had already happened by the time that Malachi was writing.

desert jackals: The desert jackals mentioned here are wild animals of the dog family (similar to wolves). They usually hunt in packs and often make a sad-

sounding cry at night. In the Bible they are almost always associated with scenes of desolation. See Job 30:29, Psalm 44:19, Isaiah 13:22, 34:13, 35:7, 43:20, Jeremiah 9:11, 10:22, 14:6, 49:33, 50:39, 51:37, Lamentations 4:3, Micah 1:8. If jackals are unknown in your area, possible substitutes might be: wolves, hyenas, or just “wild animals.”

Malachi 1:4

Section 1:2–5: The LORD loved the people of Israel very much

Paragraph 1:2–5

At the time when Malachi was writing, the people of Israel were discouraged. Some years earlier their enemies, the Babylonians, had defeated them in war and had taken them as slaves to Babylon.

After some time the people of Israel had been released and were now living again in their own land, but life was very difficult. Perhaps they felt that the LORD had failed to bless them as a nation. They questioned whether the LORD really loved them. The LORD answered this accusation by pointing out that he had chosen to love them more than other nations. He told them that he had shown this love when he chose their ancestor Jacob and entered into a covenant relationship with him and his descendants (Genesis 28:13–15, 35:9–12, 46:3–4).

1:4a

Though Edom may say,

- If the descendants of Esau, that is, the people of Edom say/boast,

Edom: This refers to the Edomites, the descendants of Edom. Edom was another name used to refer to Esau. Esau was given the name Edom, meaning “red,” because of the red stew for which he gave up his position as the eldest son of Jacob (Genesis 25:30). (Genesis 25:30, 36:1). In some languages a footnote might be helpful to explain this.

may say: The text does not tell us to whom the Edomites were speaking. It is possible that they were speaking to each other. However it is recommended that you do not specify this unless it is necessary to do so in your language.

1:4b

“We have been devastated,

- “Our^(excl) towns have been destroyed/spoilt,
- “Enemies have destroyed/spoilt our^(excl) towns,

We have been devastated: That is, our towns have been devastated/destroyed.

1:4c**but we will rebuild the ruins,”**

- but we^(excl) will build them again.”
- but it does not matter, we^(excl) will repair them.”

the ruins: This refers to what remained of Edom's towns after their enemies had destroyed them.

1:4d**this is what the LORD of Hosts says:**

- But Yahweh Sabaoth replies,
- This is what Yahweh Sabaoth says to you^(plur),

the LORD of Hosts: This special title for the LORD occurs twenty-four times in Malachi. See the discussion of this term in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section in the Introduction.

says: The text does not specify to whom the LORD was speaking here. However it is clear that he was continuing to speak to Israel about Edom. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit.

1:4e**“They may build,**

- “Even if they build their towns again,

1:4f**but I will demolish.**

- I will destroy them again.

1:4g**They will be called the Land of Wickedness,**

- Then their land will be described as, ‘the region/area where people behave wickedly.’
- Then when people talk about them, they will call them, ‘The wicked/evil country/nation.’

They will be called the Land of Wickedness: This is one way in which people described Edom.

the Land of Wickedness: This is a figure of speech. It is the people who lived in the region who were wicked, not the land itself.

1:4h**and a people with whom the LORD is indignant forever.**

- And they will also call/refer to them as, ‘the people with whom Yahweh will be angry forever.’

a people with whom the LORD is indignant forever:

This is the second way in which people described Edom:

a people: This refers to the Edomites.

with whom the LORD is indignant forever: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as is indignant

refers both to anger and the action that shows that anger. One way to say this would be:

towards whom the LORD shows his anger forever.

Malachi 1:5**Section 1:2–5: The LORD loved the people of Israel very much****Paragraph 1:2–5**

At the time when Malachi was writing, the people of Israel were discouraged. Some years earlier their enemies, the Babylonians, had defeated them in war and had taken them as slaves to Babylon.

After some time the people of Israel had been released and were now living again in their own land, but life was very difficult. Perhaps they felt that the LORD had failed to bless them as a nation. They questioned whether the LORD really loved them. The LORD answered this accusation by pointing out that he had chosen to love them more than other nations. He told them that he had shown this love when he chose their ancestor Jacob and entered into a covenant relationship with him and his descendants (Genesis 28:13–15, 35:9–12, 46:3–4).

1:5

English versions differ about whether this verse represents Malachi's words or the words of the LORD himself. They indicate this by placing their quotation marks in different places:

1. They are the LORD's words, continuing from 1:4. For example:

“...you will say, ‘Truly, the Lord's great power reaches far beyond our borders!’” (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NJB, REB, NET, GW, NCV, CEV, NLT)

1. They are Malachi's words. The LORD's words end in 1:4. For example:

“^{4h}...the people with whom the Lord is angry for ever.” ^{5a}Your own eyes shall see this... (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is likely that this verse is a continuation of what the LORD was saying to the people of Israel. This fits with the rest of the chapter, which is a conversation between the LORD and various groups of people. Therefore include these words in the quotation that you started in 1:4, so that you make it clear that the LORD was still speaking.

1:5a

You will see this with your own eyes,

- You^(plur) people of Israel will see this happening with your^(plur) own eyes,
- You^(plur) yourselves will see this.

You will see this with your own eyes: This clause emphasizes that the people of Israel would actually see these things happen to the Edomites. Another way to express this emphasis in English is:

You yourselves will see this.

1:5b

and you yourselves will say, ‘The LORD is great—even beyond the borders of Israel.’”

- and you^(plur) will say, ‘Yahweh is powerful/mighty in every place/nation, even beyond the boundaries of the land of Israel.’”

The LORD is great—even beyond the borders of Israel: This means that the greatness of the LORD extends beyond the land of Israel. He is powerful over many nations. The verb or adjective form of the Hebrew word which the BSB translates as great is also used in 1:11 (twice) and 1:14. All these verses refer to the fact that the power of the LORD is not limited to the people of Israel. His power extends to other nations as well. See also the note on 1:11.

General Comment on 1:5b

In 1:5b, the LORD was quoting what the people themselves would say. In some languages it may not be possible to use direct speech here. One way to use indirect speech instead is:

and you^(plur) shall say that the LORD is great even beyond the border of Israel!

Malachi 1:6**Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests****Paragraph 1:6–14**

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:6a

“A son honors his father,

- ¶ “A son certainly respects his father,
- ¶ “A child respects his father does he not?

1:6b

and a servant his master.

- and a servant certainly respects his master.
- Also a servant respects his master, does he not?

1:6c

But if I am a father, where is My honor?

- If I am your^(plur) father, why do you^(plur) not respect me?
- If I am your^(plur) father, why do you^(plur) not honor me in the way I deserve?
- Yet, although I am your^(plur) father, you^(plur) refuse to honor me.

1:6d

And if I am a master, where is your fear of Me?”

- And if I am your^(plur) master, why do you^(plur) not respect me?
- Although I am your^(plur) master, you^(plur) refuse to respect me.

1:6c–d

But if I am a father, where is My honor? And if I am a master, where is your fear of Me?: These two questions are rhetorical questions. Their functions are:

1. to show that honor is unquestionably due to the LORD,
2. to rebuke the hearers,
3. and to introduce the topic about which the LORD would speak.

In some languages it may be necessary to change the form of the question so that the same functions are communicated. For example, GNT uses a more natural English style:

why don’t you honor me?...why don’t you respect me? (GNT)

In other languages it may be better to use statements rather than questions to communicate these functions.

honor: The Hebrew word *kabod* which the BSB translates as honor is used frequently in the Hebrew Bible to talk about God’s glory and majesty. It also means “dignity.”

your fear of Me: The Hebrew word *mora’* which the BSB translates as fear can also mean “reverence,” “awe.” So it is translated in many English versions as “respect.”

General Comment on 1:6a–d

Notice the two pairs of parallel statements 1:6a–b and 1:6c–d. Twice the text uses two similar statements together for emphasis. This increases the impact on the hearer, and it highlights an important point:

^{6a}A son honors his father, and

^{6b}a servant honors his master.

^{6c}But if I am a father, where is My honor?

^{6d}And if I am a master, where is your fear of Me?

1:6e**says the LORD of Hosts**

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says

says the LORD of Hosts: The speech clause, says the LORD of Hosts (or “says the LORD”), occurs many times throughout the text. This emphasizes the fact that this is a direct message from the LORD. See note 1 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

Notice that in the BSB this clause occurs after the speech. This is good English style. However GNT placed this phrase at the beginning of the verse to make it clear who is speaking and to whom:

The Lord Almighty says to the priests... (GNT)

You should place it wherever is natural in your language.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d concerning this special title for the LORD. Translate it in the same way here.

1:6f**to you priests who despise My name.**

- to you^(plur) priests, who insult my name.
- “You^(plur) priests treat my authority with contempt.
- to you^(plur), the priests, who treat me as if I am nothing.

you priests: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates you priests is a vocative—the LORD was addressing the priests directly. In some languages vocative phrases are usually placed at the beginning of the

sentence. You should place the phrase where it would be natural in your language.

priests: The main function of a Jewish priest was to be the mediator between the people and the LORD, and make sacrifices to the LORD on behalf of the people.

who despise My name: By describing the priests this way, the text summarizes their failure to honor the LORD.

despise: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as despise means “to hold in contempt,” that is, to consider something unimportant.

My name: In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “the LORD’s name” or My name refers to the LORD himself or his authority. Baldwin (1972), page 225; Merrill (1994), page 401. When the priests despised the name of the LORD, they were despising the LORD himself and treating him with contempt. GNT simply uses “me” instead of My name.

1:6g**“But you ask, ‘How have we despised Your name?’**

- Yet you^(plur) say, ‘How have we^(excl) ever despised you^(sing)?’
- Yet you^(plur) say/claim that you^(plur) have not despised my name.

But you ask, ‘How have we despised Your name?’:

This is a rhetorical question. Its function is to disagree with the LORD’s statement. The priests were claiming that they had not despised the LORD’s name. If you do not use rhetorical questions in this way in your language, it may be necessary to express the idea with a statement. For example:

Yet you say, “We have not despised your name.”

In this statement the LORD quoted the priests’ words. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for the statement. One way to do this would be:

Yet you claim that you have not despised my name.

Your name: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as Your name refers to the LORD himself or his authority. Baldwin (1972), page 225; Merrill (1994), page 401. See also the note on 1:6f. When the priests despised the name of the LORD, they were despising the LORD himself.

GNT simply uses “you” instead of Your name. You may also do this if it would be clearer in your translation.

Malachi 1:7

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:7a

By presenting defiled food on My altar.

- You^(plur) offer defiled/unholy/unclean animals to me on my altar.
- This is how you^(plur) have despised me: you^(plur) bring polluted/unacceptable animals and sacrifice them to me on my altar.

This verse is the answer to the question in 1:6g. GNT begins this verse with the phrase “This is how,” to make this connection explicit. It may be necessary in your language to do something similar.

By presenting: In Hebrew this literally is “you are bringing.” When used with “upon my altar,” this is the normal expression for bringing sacrifices to the LORD.

defiled food: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as defiled can also be translated as “polluted.” Although GNT uses the word “worthless,” the meaning here is not that the sacrifices had little value. Instead, it means that the sacrifices were “ritually unclean,” “unholy,” and therefore unfit to be used as a sacrifice to the LORD. In the laws which the LORD had given to Moses many years previously, he said that animals offered for sacrifice must be perfect. See Exodus 12:5; Leviticus 1:3, 1:10, 22:18–25; Deuteronomy 15:21.

food: This is the general word in Hebrew for “bread,” “food” or “grain,” but here it refers to animal sacrifices, as 1:8 makes clear.

on My altar: The altar is the place where the priest burned the sacrifice. The altar was a large structure, shaped like a box, made of bronze. It stood in the temple outside the Holy Place.

1:7b

But you ask, ‘How have we defiled You?’

- You^(plur) do this, and yet you^(plur) still ask, ‘How have we^(excl) dishonored you?’^(sing)

- When you^(plur) do this, you^(plur) still say/claim that you^(plur) have not defiled me.

How have we defiled You?: There is a textual issue with this verse. There are two possibilities:

1. The Hebrew text reads: “How have we polluted you?” (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, GW, NET, REB, NASB, KJV, NJPS)
2. The LXX reads, “How have we polluted it?” (RSV, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the Hebrew text. This again shows that “the name” in 1:6g stands for the LORD himself.

This statement is parallel to “How have we despised Your name?” in 1:6g. This is another rhetorical question. The people again objected to the LORD saying that they had treated him badly. Use the appropriate grammatical form in your language to show this.

defiled: In some languages it may not be natural to speak of “defiling” God. The idea is that they were dishonoring him. They did that by bringing defective offerings. It may be necessary to express the idea in a different way. For example:

How have we failed to respect you? (GNT)

How have we offended you? (NET)

1:7c

By saying that the table of the LORD is contemptible.

- You^(plur) act as if my altar is not worthy to be respected.
- This is how you^(plur) have insulted me: You^(plur) think that it is proper/fitting to take things that are unacceptable and offer them to me Yahweh.

This clause is the answer to the question in 1:7b. In some languages it may be necessary to make this connection more explicit. For example:

You have done it by... (CEV)

the table of the LORD: This refers to the altar on which sacrifices were offered to the LORD in the temple. This is a figure of speech which refers to the whole act of offering sacrifices to the LORD.

Notice that the LORD referred to his own altar as the table of the LORD. In some languages this may be confusing. If that is true in your language, you may

substitute a first person form like “my.” GNT has “my altar.”

contemptible: The Hebrew word is related to the word translated as “despised” in 1:6. See the note on 1:6f above.

General Comment on 1:6–7

Notice the special structure in 1:6–7. This highlights an important point in the text.

^{6g}But you ask, ‘How have we despised Your name?’

^{7a}By presenting defiled food on My altar.

^{7b}But you ask, ‘How have we defiled You?’

^{7c}By saying that the table of the LORD is contemptible.

The same Hebrew verb *bazah* “to despise, to treat with contempt” appears in verse parts 1:6g and 1:7c, where the BSB translates it as “contemptible.” The verse parts 1:7a and 1:7b contain the Hebrew verb *gaʿal*, which means “to pollute, to defile, to make unclean or unholy.”

Malachi 1:8

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:8a

When you offer blind animals for sacrifice,

- For example, you^(plur) bring animals that are blind and sacrifice them to me.

blind animals: This was one category of animal which the LORD forbade the people to bring him as a sacrifice. See Leviticus 22:22.

1:8b, d

is it not wrong?

- Is that not evil/bad?
- Is that good? No.
- That is evil.

is it not wrong?: That is, “is there nothing wrong in doing that?” This is a rhetorical question which expresses the LORD’s strong indignation. If you use rhetorical questions for such purposes in your language, use one in both 1:8b and 1:8d. However if a rhetorical question would not be appropriate, you can use a statement in both places. See 1:8b and 1:8d in the Display for examples of both.

1:8c

And when you present the lame and sick ones,

- You^(plur) also bring animals that are lame/injured or sick.

the lame and sick ones: These too were categories of animals which the LORD forbade the people to bring him as sacrifices. See Leviticus 22:22.

1:8d

is it not wrong?

- Is that not evil/bad?
- Is that good? No.
- That is evil.

1:8e

Try offering them to your governor!

- Go^(sing) and take an animal of that kind and give^(sing) it as a gift to your^(sing) governor.
- If you^(sing) took animals like that and gave them to your^(sing) chief/leader,

Try offering them: That is, offer that sort of animal.

governor: A governor is usually different from a chief or king in that he is an official appointed to administer a certain region. A governor often represents a foreign power that is ruling the country by force. See Nehemiah 5:14–15.

1:8f

Would he be pleased with you

- Will he be pleased?
- would such gifts from you^(sing) please him? No.
- you^(sing) will not please him with such a gift.

1:8g

or show you favor?”

- Would he grant you^(sing) favor?”
- Would he treat you^(sing) kindly?” No.
- Neither will he treat you^(sing) kindly.”

1:8f–g

This is another set of parallel rhetorical questions. They expect the answer “no.” Here the LORD was asserting something that the people knew was true: that an earthly ruler would not be pleased with an imperfect offering. Use the appropriate grammatical

form in your language to show this in both of these parts of the verse.

1:8h

asks the LORD of Hosts.

- Those are the words of Yahweh Sabaoth.
- Yahweh Sabaoth has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaoth says to you^(plur).

asks the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

General Comment on 1:8a–h

There are further examples of doublets and rhetorical questions in this verse, showing the strong emotion:

^{8a}When you offer blind animals for sacrifice, ^{8b}is it not wrong?

^{8c}And when you present the lame and sick ones, ^{8d}is it not wrong?

^{8f}...Would he be pleased with you

^{8g}or show you favor?

Malachi 1:9

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:9

Scholars do not agree as to who is speaking in 1:9. There are three main interpretations:

1. Both Malachi and the LORD speak in 1:9. In 1:9a it was Malachi himself who was appealing to the priests to repent. In 1:9b–c it was the LORD who was speaking. For example:

But now plead for God's favor that he might be gracious to us. "With this kind of thing in your hands, how can he be pleased with you?" asks the sovereign Lord. (NET) This fits with the use of the Hebrew first person pronoun "us" in 1:9a and with

the speech clause "said the LORD of hosts" at the end of the verse.

1. The LORD himself spoke all the words of 1:9. The main problem with this interpretation is the use of the first person pronoun "us" in 1:9a, which is not translated in the BSB. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB) Some versions follow the LXX and use "you" here to avoid this problem. (CEV, GW, REB, NCV, NLT)
2. Malachi spoke all 1:9 as a comment. This fits with the pronoun "us" and the third person reference to God in 1:9c. There are other precedents for the use of the third person to refer to himself in the words that the LORD, so this in itself does not prove that the LORD is not speaking here. But the use of the first person pronoun "us" seems to be fairly conclusive evidence that the prophet is speaking at this point. But the use of the speech clause "says the LORD of hosts" in 1:9d seems to contradict this interpretation. GNT follows this interpretation, but only by moving the speech clause out of 1:9 altogether:

^{8f,g}"Would he be pleased with you or grant you any favors?" ⁹Now, you priests, try asking God to be good to us. He will not answer your prayer, and it will be your fault. ¹⁰The Lord Almighty says, "I wish one of you would close..." (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). See the Meaning Line in the Display for an example of this interpretation.

1:9a

"But ask now for God's favor. Will He be gracious?"

- And yet you^(plur) bring that kind of gift to God and beg God/him to be kind/good to us^(incl).

But ask now for God's favor. Will He be gracious?:

Most English versions and some commentators interpret this sentence as irony. This could be translated as:

What good will it do if you entreat the favor of God, when you keep on doing the kind of things you are doing?

Go ahead, beg God to be merciful to you! But when you bring that kind of offering, why should he show you any favor at all? (NLT)

The preceding and following contexts are then ironic. In other words, they were a strong rebuke to the priests because they were being hypocritical:

they begged for mercy but at the same time offered unclean sacrifices. Some versions (REB) and commentators interpret 1:9a as a genuine appeal to the priests to repent, offering the expectation that the Lord will have mercy. But this is a minority view.

ask: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as ask means “to pray, beg, plead, entreat.”

God: This is one of the few places in the book in which the general term for God, *ʾel*, is used, rather than the personal name Yahweh. This may be because of the contrast between God and a human governor (1:8e).

1:9b–c

In these verse parts the LORD asked a rhetorical question. He used this question to rebuke the priests and to emphasize that he would not bless them when they brought improper offerings.

If you do not use rhetorical questions in this way in your language, it may be necessary to use a statement. For example:

If you despise him by bringing such offerings, he certainly will not show you favor!

1:9b

Since this has come from your hands,

- “When you^(plur) give him such gifts,
- “If you despise him by bringing such offerings,

Since this has come from your hands: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as come from your hands literally means “this is from your hand.” There are two main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. “This” refers to the offerings of maimed animals described in 1:8. In other words, “if you bring him that kind of an offering...” In this context from your hands means “from you.” For example:

But when you bring that kind of offering... (NLT)
(BSB, RSV, NIV, NLT, NCV, NET, NASB)

1. The statement, “this is from your hand,” means “this is your fault,” or “this is your responsibility.” For example:

and it will be your fault. (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NJPS, GW, NRSV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). For discussion of other possible interpretations, see Pohlig (1998), pages 44–46. But in spite of these

differences of interpretation, all commentators and versions agree on the essential meaning.

1:9c

will He show you favor?”

- do you^(plur) think he will agree to favor/bless you?^(plur)
No, not at all.”
- you^(plur) should know that he will certainly not favor/bless you!^(plur)”

will He show you favor: The LORD referred to himself here as if he were speaking about someone else, by using the third person pronoun He. In some languages this may be confusing. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to indicate that the LORD was referring to himself. For example:

how can I show favor to any of you?

1:9d

asks the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

asks the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

Malachi 1:10

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:10c

I take no pleasure in you,”

- I am not pleased with you^(plur).”
- The way you^(plur) behave does not please me at all.”

1:10

All versions are agreed that it is the LORD who was speaking again here.

1:10a

“Oh, that one of you would shut the temple doors,

- “If only someone among you^(plur) would close/lock the doors of the temple

- “I wish that one of you^(plur) would shut the entrance of my temple

Oh, that one of you would shut the temple doors: In 1:10a–b, the LORD was saying that it would be better to shut the temple doors altogether and offer no sacrifices at all, rather than to continue bringing damaged and unacceptable sacrifices (1:7–8).

It is clear from the context (1:6) that the LORD would have preferred the priests to honor him by bringing proper sacrifices.

Consider how to express this idea in the best way in your language. One way to express this in English would be to say,

It would be better if one of you would just shut the temple doors.

one of you: The pronoun you refers to the priests.

shut the temple doors: This refers to the double doors at the entrance to the part of the temple where the priests offered sacrifices. In other words, the LORD did not want the priests to make any more sacrifices of the kind he had described. If the doors were shut, then the priests could no longer go in and offer those sacrifices.

In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit in the text or use a footnote to explain it.

1:10b

so that you would no longer kindle useless fires on My altar!

- so that you^(plur) priests could no longer light fires to make these worthless sacrifices on my altar.

so that you would no longer kindle useless fires on My altar: When the priests sacrificed an animal, they killed it and then burnt it on the altar. So if the priests could not light a fire, they would not be able to offer the sacrifices.

useless: The fire and the sacrifices were useless because the LORD would not accept them. Other ways to translate this are “worthless,” “pointless.”

1:10d

says the LORD of Hosts,

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term the same way here.

1:10e

“and I will accept no offering from your hands.

- “So I will reject completely the offerings/gifts that you^(plur) bring to me.

from your hands: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as from your hands means “from you.” The same Hebrew expression was used in 1:9b.

Malachi 1:11

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:11

The theme of 1:11 is the greatness of the LORD and the fact that he is honored among the nations. This theme returns to the theme which was introduced in 1:5 and will be repeated again in 1:14. This is the reason that the LORD made his covenant with the people of Israel, so that through them people of all nations would come to know him.

1:11a

For My name will be great among the nations,

- For my name is respected/known-as-great by the peoples of the earth
- Surely people of all nations honor me/my name.

For: The Hebrew word *ki* which the BSB translates as *For* introduces a general reason that the LORD will not accept their offerings. In some languages this reason may not be obvious. The text implies that because the LORD is very great and worshipped throughout the world, he would not accept their offerings that showed disrespect for him. Many English versions translate this Hebrew word as “for.” Some versions omit it. Use what would be natural in your language in this context to state the reason that the LORD did not accept their offerings.

My name will be great among the nations: There is no verb in the Hebrew text of 1:11a. However in English a verb is required. Most versions have chosen a form of the verb “to be.” However they differ in the tense they choose:

1. Some versions use the present tense “is.” (RSV, GNT, NJB, CEV, REB, NLT, NJPS)

2. Other versions use the future tense “will be.” (BSB, NIV, NCV, GW, NASB, KJV, NET)

Either tense is possible from the Hebrew. If there is a way to maintain this ambiguity of tense in your translation, do so. But if you must choose a verb tense, it is recommended that you follow option (1) and use the present tense.

This probably refers to the fact that some people from other nations were beginning to believe in and follow Yahweh, the God of the people of Israel. However there is also a future, prophetic meaning that points to those people from all nations who were going to believe in God in the future (Baldwin (1972), pages 228–230).

the nations: The Hebrew word *goyim* which the BSB translates as nations was the word which the Jews used to refer to the Gentiles, the people of all the other nations.

1:11b
from where the sun rises to where it sets.

- from the east to the west.
- in every part of the world, from where the sun rises to where it sets.

from where the sun rises to where it sets: This is a figure of speech. It refers to every part of the world, from the farthest point east to the farthest point west.

1:11c
In every place, incense

- In every place they burn incense that smells sweet to please me,

1:11d
and pure offerings will be presented in My name,

- and offer sacrifices to me that please/are-acceptable-to me.
- and bring me gifts/sacrifices that are proper/fitting

1:11c-d

incense: The priests not only burnt animals as sacrifices, but sometimes incense was also used (see Leviticus 2:1). The word incense refers to a substance which smells sweet when it is burnt.

1:11e
because My name will be great among the nations,”

- For my name is respected/known-as-great by the peoples of the earth.”
- because people of all nations honor me/my name.”

My name will be great among the nations: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as My

name will be great among the nations was also used in 1:11a.

General Comment on 1:11b–e

This verse has a chiasmic structure (that is, a crossed structure) in Hebrew. This highlights a climax in the text:

^{11a} My name will be great among the nations,

^{11c} In every place, incense

^{11d} and pure offerings will be presented in My name,

^{11e} because My name will be great among the nations.

1:11f
says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

Malachi 1:12

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:12a

“But you profane it

- “But you^(plur) insult my name
- “But you^(plur), priests, you^(plur) do not honor me/my name

But you: The pronoun you is emphatic here and refers to the priests. The disrespectful actions of the priests are contrasted with the respect that other nations gave to the LORD (1:11).

profane: The verb which the BSB translates as profane means “profane, dishonor, treat as unholy/common.” The same verb is used in 2:10d and 2:11c.

it: There is a textual issue in this verse. Scholars do not agree about whether the object of “profane” should be “it” or “me.” So there are two options:

1. The object should be “it.” The pronoun “it” refers to the LORD’s name. For example:

But you are profaning it. (NET) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, NLT, NJPS, NASB, KJV, GW)

1. The object should be “me,” that is, the LORD. For example:

But you don’t honor me. (NCV) (GNT, NCV, CEV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as it seems to be the more likely solution to the textual issue.

However there is very little difference in meaning between the two options. The pronoun it here refers to the LORD’s name, and the LORD’s name is a way to refer to the LORD himself. Therefore, it is acceptable to follow option (2) if it would be more natural and clearer in your language.

1:12b

when you say, ‘The table of the Lord is defiled,

- when you^(plur) say that it does not matter what kind of sacrifices you^(plur) offer to me, the Lord/Master.

The table of the Lord: This is the altar on which sacrifices were offered to God in the temple. This is a figure of speech for the whole act of offering sacrifices to God. See the note on 1:7c.

Lord: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as Lord here is *ʾadonay*. This title refers to God as “lord/master.” It is different from his personal name Yahweh. Both terms refer to God.

Notice that in 1:7c, the Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as “table of the LORD” does indeed use Yahweh. So 1:7c and 1:12b differ in the Hebrew text. Try to preserve this distinction in your translation. See the discussion of these terms in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section in the Introduction.

defiled: This is the same verb as in 1:7a and 1:7b.

General Comment on 1:12b

Notice that the LORD continued to refer to himself as though he were talking about someone else. If that is confusing in your language, it may be necessary to indicate that he was talking about himself. For example:

But you dishonor me when you say that my altar is worthless and when you offer on it food that you despise. (GNT)

But you insult me when you say that it does not matter what kind of sacrifices you offer to me, the Lord.

1:12c

and as for its fruit, its food is contemptible.’

- So you^(plur) bring sacrifices of food that are worthless/not-acceptable and give them to me.

and as for its fruit, its food is contemptible: That is, it does not matter what kind of worthless food/offering you bring to give to God. The food spoken of here is the meat (animal) and cereal offerings which the priests placed upon the altar.

contemptible: This is the same Hebrew verb as in 1:6f, 1:7c, also 2:9a.

Malachi 1:13

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:13a

You also say: ‘Oh, what a nuisance!’

- ‘We^(excl) are tired of offering all these sacrifices,’ you^(plur) say;
- You^(plur) say, ‘What a bother/burden all these sacrifices are.’

You also say: Notice that the BSB and the Hebrew have placed this speech clause at the beginning of 1:13a. In other languages it may be necessary to place it at the end of the verse.

Oh, what a nuisance: Here the LORD described the attitude of the priests towards the sacrificial system he had given them. They thought of it as a burden and they were bored with it.

1:13b

And you turn up your nose at it,”

- And you^(plur) treat these things contemptuously/disdainfully.”

And you turn up your nose at it: There is a textual problem with this part of the verse. There are two possibilities:

1. Follow the Hebrew texts that can be translated as “sniff at it.” (BSB, NIV, REB, NET, NJPS, NLT, GW, NCV, NASB, KJV)
2. Follow the Hebrew texts that can be translated as “sniff at me.” (GNT, RSV, NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). While “sniff at it” is probably the correct reading, by showing disdain for the altar and sacrificial system, the priests were also holding the LORD himself in contempt.

turn up your nose at: That is, degrade or treat contemptuously. In some languages there may be a suitable idiom to express this idea.

it: This refers to the altar (the LORD’s table) and the sacrificial system.

1:13c

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

1:13d

“You bring offerings that are stolen,

- “You^(plur) bring me an animal that has been stolen
- “You^(plur) offer me an animal as a sacrifice that you^(plur) have taken by force

offerings that are stolen: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as offerings that are stolen can have several meanings. The two most common possibilities here are:

1. It refers to animals which someone stole or seized by force. This is the most common meaning of the Hebrew word. Cohen (1985), the Jewish commentator, takes the definite position that the sense here is ‘stolen.’ For example:

you bring a stolen animal. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NJB, CEV, NASB, GW, NET, NJPS)

1. It refers to animals which had been attacked and injured. God did not accept injured or mutilated animals as sacrifices (Exodus 22:31). For example:

you bring injured...animals. (NIV) (NIV, NCV, KJV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

1:13e

lame, or sick!

- or is lame or sick. This you^(plur) bring me as your^(plur) offering.
- or you^(plur) bring an animal that is injured or is sick. Then you^(plur) offer that as a sacrifice.

lame, or sick: These were categories of animals which were not allowed as sacrifices. See the note on 1:8c.

1:13f

Should I accept these from your hands?”

- Do you think I will accept that kind of sacrifice from you?^(plur) No, I will not.”
- Do you^(plur) think that kind of offering will please me? No, it will not.”
- You^(plur) should realise that I will not accept a sacrifice like that from you^(plur).”

Should I accept these from your hands?: This is a rhetorical question. It is an emphatic way to say that such offerings were unacceptable to the LORD. If your language would not use a rhetorical question to express this meaning, you may use a statement. For example:

You bring them as gifts, but I won’t accept them from you. (NCV)

from your hands: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as from your hands means “from you.” The same Hebrew expression was used in 1:9b and 1:10e.

1:13g

asks the LORD.

- These are the words of Yahweh.
- Yahweh has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh says to you^(plur).

asks the LORD: See the note on 1:2b.

Malachi 1:14

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 1:6–14

In this paragraph the LORD rebuked the priests because they were bringing imperfect animals to sacrifice to him. By doing this they showed that they did not respect or honor him.

This part of the speech was addressed most strongly to the priests. However Malachi 1:13–14 shows that the people were included too.

1:14a

“But cursed is the deceiver

- “Cursed be any person who tries to cheat me
- “I curse any person who tries to cheat/deceive me

But cursed is the deceiver: “Cursing” is the opposite of blessing. The LORD will not only refuse to bless a man who is cursed, but may also take away good things that are in that man’s life. Since the LORD spoke these words, this is a definite statement of what he will do (“I will curse...”), not just a wish.

1:14b

who has an acceptable male in his flock

- like this: he has a good/perfect male animal among his sheep and/or goats,

his flock: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as flock refers to the groups of sheep and goats.

1:14c

and vows to give it,

- and he has already promised to give it to me.

1:14d

but sacrifices a defective animal to the Lord.

- Then instead he sacrifices to me, the Lord, an imperfect animal
- But then he offers me, the Master, a different animal with a defect.

a defective animal: This refers to an animal which is blemished somehow. This includes animals that were blind, lame or sick. In fact, it includes all the types of defects that the author has mentioned.

the Lord: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as Lord here is *ʾadonay*, not God’s personal name Yahweh. It means “master, lord.” See the first occurrence of this word in 1:12b.

General Comment on 1:14d

Again, the LORD spoke of himself as though he was talking about someone else. If that is confusing in

your language, it may be necessary to indicate that the LORD referred to himself. For example:

by sacrificing a defective animal to me! (NJB)

1:14e

For I am a great King,”

- Do not forget^(plur) that I am a great king.”
- I will curse him because I am a great king.”
- Am I not a great king?”

For: The Hebrew word *ki* which the BSB translates as For introduces the reason that the LORD will not accept blemished animals as sacrifices. Most English versions translate it as “for” or “because.” Some versions omit it. Use what would be natural in your language in this context to state the LORD’s reason for cursing such a person.

1:14f

says the LORD of Hosts,

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaoth.
- Yahweh Sabaoth has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaoth says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

1:14g

“and My name is to be feared among the nations.”

- “My name is feared/honored among all the nations.”
- “People of all the nations fear/respect me.”

My name: In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “the LORD’s name” or My name refers to God himself or his authority. Baldwin (1972), page 225; Merrill (1994), page 401. It was also used in this way in 1:6. See the note on 1:6f. GNT prefers to use “me” instead of My name to make this clear.

feared: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as feared can also be translated “respected, honored.”

the nations: The Hebrew word *goyim* which the BSB translates as nations was the word which the Jews used to refer to the Gentiles, the people of all the other nations. It was also used in this way in 1:11a.

General Comment on 1:14a–g

In some languages it may be helpful to re-order this verse. GNT provides one model for this:

^{14a}A curse on the cheater ^{14d}who sacrifices a worthless animal to me, ^{14b}when he has in his flock a

good [male] animal ^{14c}that he promised to give me! ^{14e}For I am a great king, ^{14g}and people of all nations fear me, ^{14f}[says the Lord Almighty]. (GNT)

Malachi 2:1

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 2:1–4

The LORD continued to rebuke the priests in this paragraph. He warned them that they would be punished if they did not repent.

Some English versions have a section heading at this point. However the main theme is the same as in the previous chapter. It is recommended that you not create a heading here. However, if a Bible in another language that churches use widely in your area has a heading here, you may need to follow that same format.

2:1

“And now this decree is for you, O priests:

- ¶ “Furthermore, O priests, this warning that I am giving is for you^(plur).
- ¶ “You^(plur) priests, listen, this is the command that I give/command you^(plur).

In the Hebrew text, the speaker, “the LORD of hosts,” is not identified until 2:2d. If this would cause difficulty in your translation, you can move the speech clause forward from 2:2d to the beginning of the chapter. GNT does this:

The Lord Almighty says to the priests... (GNT)

And now: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as now is a time word. It is preceded by the conjunction w-, usually translated as “and.” The LORD used this expression to introduce the next things he would say. It emphasizes that these things were important. In some languages, it may not be natural to use a time word to express this meaning. Some other ways to say this are:

Listen, you priests; this command is for you! (NLT)

I, the Lord All-Powerful, have something else to say to you priests. (CEV)

Some English versions omit this phrase. Use what would be natural in your language to present another important topic as part of the same discourse.

decree: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as decree can also be translated “warning” (GW). That is, it refers to a solemn, unchangeable decree/pronouncement. In this context it refers to the warnings which follow in 2:2–9. The same Hebrew word is translated as “commandment” in 2:4a.

O priests: The LORD was still speaking to the priests. In some languages it may be necessary to put this expression at the start of the speech. For example:

Priests, this command is for you. (NCV)

Malachi 2:2

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 2:1–4

The LORD continued to rebuke the priests in this paragraph. He warned them that they would be punished if they did not repent.

Some English versions have a section heading at this point. However the main theme is the same as in the previous chapter. It is recommended that you not create a heading here. However, if a Bible in another language that churches use widely in your area has a heading here, you may need to follow that same format.

2:2a

If you do not listen,

- If you^(plur) refuse to listen to/heed my words,

2:2b

and if you do not take it to heart

- and if you^(plur) do not take this warning seriously

take it to heart: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as take it to heart is a figure of speech. In this context it means to understand that the command is an important matter and to sincerely resolve to obey it.

2:2c

to honor My name,”

- to honor my-name/me,”

honor: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as honor is kabod. A form of this word was used in 1:6c, in the rhetorical question, “where is My honor?” In some languages it may be possible to use a similar expression to translate this idea in both verses.

My name: Here the phrase My name means the same thing as “me.” See the notes on 1:6f and 1:14g.

2:2d**says the LORD of Hosts,**

- these are the words of Yahweh Sabaot,
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken,
- this is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur),

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

Notice that GNT placed this phrase at the beginning of the paragraph to make it clear who was speaking and to whom:

The Lord Almighty says to the priests... (GNT)

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

2:2e**“I will send a curse among you,**

- “then I will curse you^(plur) severely.
- “I will cause you^(plur) to be greatly cursed.

I will send a curse among you: Although the Hebrew uses the article “the” here, it does not imply that there has been a particular previously mentioned curse. Instead, the definite article implies “a very great curse.” Verhoef (1987).

In Hebrew culture, once a curse was spoken, it was certain to take place. Baldwin (1972), page 232 See also the discussion of curse in 1:14a.

send: In some languages it may not be natural to say, “I will send a curse.” Other ways to express this are, “I will speak a curse” or “I will cause a curse to be on you.”

2:2f**and I will curse your blessings.**

- I will cause your^(plur) special privileges to be harmful to you^(plur), rather than helpful.

your blessings: Scholars differ about what the phrase your blessings refers to in this verse. There are at least two main views:

1. It refers to the special privileges which the priests had. They served the LORD in the temple. Because of the work that they did there, they received the gifts which the other tribes of Israel gave to the LORD. The LORD was warning the priests that he would take away their privileges. For example:

I will put a curse on the things you receive for your support. (GNT)

1. It refers to the blessings that the priests pronounced for the people to ask the LORD to favor them. The LORD was warning the priests that he would no longer use their words to bless the people. Instead, he would use the words of the blessings to harm the people. For example:

Otherwise, when you give a blessing, I will turn it into a curse. (CEV)

Most English versions are ambiguous, and both interpretations are possible. If you must choose between them in your translation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

2:2g**Yes, I have already begun to curse them,**

- The truth is, I have already cursed those privileges
- In fact, this has already happened

2:2h**because you are not taking it to heart.**

- because you^(plur) do not take my warning seriously.

because: The Hebrew word *ki* which the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that the LORD had already cursed the priests' blessings. Most English versions have because here. See the notes on 1:11a and 1:14e, where this same Hebrew word was used. Use what would be natural in your language for this context.

you are not taking it to heart: See the note on 2:2b.

Malachi 2:3**Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests****Paragraph 2:1–4**

The LORD continued to rebuke the priests in this paragraph. He warned them that they would be punished if they did not repent.

Some English versions have a section heading at this point. However the main theme is the same as in the previous chapter. It is recommended that you not create a heading here. However, if a Bible in another language that churches use widely in your area has a heading here, you may need to follow that same format.

2:3a**Behold, I will rebuke your descendants,**

- Because of what you^(plur) have done, I will punish your^(plur) descendants,
- Listen/Watch-out^(plur). Because of what you^(plur) have done, I will cause your^(plur) descendants to suffer.

In this verse the LORD gave a vivid description of one way he would “curse their blessings,” as he mentioned in 2:2. Unlike most verses in Hebrew, this one does not begin with a connector. However in some languages it may be helpful to use a transition phrase. For example:

Because of you I will rebuke your descendants.
(NIV)

Behold: The Hebrew word *hinneh* which the BSB translates as Behold is difficult to translate. Many English versions leave it untranslated because it has no equivalent in English (NIV, GNT, NJPS, NRSV, NCV, GW, REB, NLT, CEV).

The usual function of *hinneh* is to direct the attention of the reader or listener to what follows. The Hebrew word expresses “the immediacy, the here-and-now-ness of the situation” (Lambdin 1971, page 168). Here, the LORD described what would happen immediately. Try to find a way to produce this effect in your translation. For example:

Now, I am going to break... (NJB)

I am about to discipline... (NET)

I will rebuke your descendants: That is, I will punish your descendants.

descendants: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as descendants literally means “seed.” Most versions and commentators understand this to refer to the descendants of the priests. There are a number of interpretation difficulties in this verse of which the most important arise from the fact that the word translated “offspring” is literally “seed.” The NJPS translation, “I will put your seed under a ban,” seems to interpret this to mean literal seed. Rebuking “the seed” would then mean “causing their crops to fail” or “damaging their crops.” There is a full discussion of this in Glazier-McDonald (1987).

2:3b

and I will spread dung on your faces, the waste from your feasts,

- and I will rub your^(plur) faces in the excrement from the intestines of the animals that you^(plur) bring and sacrifice to me,
- I will take some excrement from the intestines of the animals that you^(plur) bring and sacrifice to me and rub it on your^(plur) faces.

I will spread dung on your faces: This is a shocking picture. The LORD was saying that he would rub the faces of the priests in or with the excrement of the animals they sacrificed. This, of course, would make the priests ritually unclean and unable to serve the LORD in his temple and to offer sacrifices there.

dung: The Hebrew word *pereš* which the BSB translates as dung refers to the excrement that came from the intestines of a sacrificed animal. These were the parts of the animal which were considered unclean and which were to be taken outside the temple and burnt. See Exodus 29:14; Leviticus 4:11, 8:17, 16:27; Numbers 19:5.

2:3c

and you will be carried off with it.

- and I will also send you^(plur) away, and throw you^(plur) out with the rubbish/dung.
- I will remove you^(plur) from serving me in the same way that you^(plur) dispose of the animal excrement.

you will be carried off with it: The Hebrew clause which the BSB translates as you will be carried off with it literally means “and someone/he will carry you off with it.” Here the LORD referred to the custom of taking unacceptable parts of sacrificed animals outside the camp to be thrown away or burned. He implied that the priests were of no value to him and would be carried away with these unacceptable, useless things.

The LORD probably did not mean that he would literally cause the priests to be taken to the dung heap. This was an emphatic way to say that he would remove them from their work just like they removed the excrement and disposed of it. There are two possibilities for translation:

- Use the figure explicitly.

...splatter your faces with the dung of your festival sacrifices, and I will add you to the dung heap.
(NLT)

...the excrement from your festival sacrifices. You will be discarded with it. (GW) (BSB, NIV, NLT, GNT, GW, NJPS, NJB, NCV, NASB)

- Omit the figure in 2:3c and translate the meaning directly. For example:

and I shall banish you from my presence. (REB)

and then be done with you. (CEV) (RSV, REB, CEV)

Use the option that communicates best in your language.

Malachi 2:4

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 2:1–4

The LORD continued to rebuke the priests in this paragraph. He warned them that they would be punished if they did not repent.

Some English versions have a section heading at this point. However the main theme is the same as in the previous chapter. It is recommended that you not create a heading here. However, if a Bible in another language that churches use widely in your area has a heading here, you may need to follow that same format.

2:4a

Then you will know that I have sent you this commandment

- At that time you^(plur) will know that I have given you^(plur) this warning,
- Then you^(plur) will know that it is I Yahweh who am warning you^(plur),

Then: The word Then in the BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction *w-*. It connects 2:3 and 2:4. Probably this connection expresses both time and result. “As a result of” the LORD’s punishment of the priests in 2:3, they would know “at that time...” Some English versions also use “so,” which can imply both time and result. Use an option which is natural here in your language.

commandment: This is the same Hebrew word which was translated as “decree” in 2:1. It highlights the theme of serious warning. 2:4 closes this paragraph, but it also introduces the reference to Levi which is expanded in the next paragraph.

2:4b

so that My covenant with Levi may continue,”

- so that the covenant which I made with Levi may continue.”
- I am giving you^(plur) this warning so that the covenant which I made long ago with the descendants of Levi will not be broken/annulled.”

so that My covenant with Levi may continue: There was hope for these priests if they would repent and obey the LORD. The Scriptures never speak of the LORD breaking his covenant with anyone. Baldwin (1972), pages 233–235.

covenant: The word covenant is a theme word in the second chapter of Malachi and indeed through the whole book. See the discussion of this term in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section in the Introduction.

Levi: The priests were all descendants of Jacob’s son Levi. If your readers do not know this, they will not understand the argument here. There are two ways to supply the information:

- Place it in the text as GNT has done:

the priests, the descendants of Levi. (GNT)

- Use a footnote.

Levi himself was not a priest and Scripture does not mention any specific covenant with Levi. However Numbers 25:10–13 speaks of a “covenant of peace” and a “covenant of an everlasting priesthood.” The LORD made this covenant with Phinehas, a descendant of Levi. This verse may refer to that event.

2:4c

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

Malachi 2:5

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 2:5–7

The Hebrew text uses singular pronouns in 2:5–7 which refer back to Levi. However the reference here is not to Levi himself. It refers to his descendants, the priests of earlier days, who obeyed the LORD. GNT uses the plural form in this paragraph and in the following verses to indicate that the verses refer to more than one person. Similarly, the NCV translates this reference to Levi in 2:5 as:

My agreement for priests was with the tribe of Levi. (NCV)

You should consider if you should do the same in your translation. Make sure that you are consistent in your use of singular or plural pronouns in this section.

2:5a

“My covenant with him was one of life and peace,

- ¶ “The covenant that I made with Levi was to give him and his descendants life and well-being
- ¶ Yahweh also says: “Long ago when I made that covenant with the descendants of Levi, I promised them that I would give them peace/well-being

one of life and peace: That is, a covenant through which Levi’s descendants would receive life and live in peace/security.

peace: The Hebrew word shalom which the BSB translates as peace means much more than the English word “peace.” It can refer to the state of blessing that results from someone living according to the LORD’s will. This peace included feeling well and whole. See also 2:6c.

2:5b
which I gave to him;

- and I gave that to him and his descendants,
- and I did as I had promised them,

which I gave to him: That is, I did as I had promised him.

which: That is, life and peace.

him: That is, Levi (and his descendants).

2:5c
it called for reverence,

- so that he might revere me.
- I did this so that they might revere/honor me.

it called for reverence: Scholars disagree about the way this clause relates to 2:5b. There are at least three views:

1. It expresses purpose. The LORD gave Levi and his descendants a covenant of life and peace so that they might respect the LORD. For example:

and this is what I gave them, so that they might respect me. (GNT) (GNT, RSV, NCV, NET, GW)

1. It expresses the covenant’s requirements. In other words, the LORD’s covenant of life and peace gave them the responsibility to revere the LORD and his covenant. For example:

This called for reverence from them. (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NLT, CEV, REB, NASB)

1. It expresses the type of covenant, just as “life and peace” do. In other words, it was a covenant of reverence towards him, as well as life and peace. For example:

My covenant was with him—a covenant of life and peace, and these were what I gave him—a covenant of respect... (NJB) (NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

reverence: The purpose of the covenant (2:5a) was to cause Levi and his descendants to respect and revere the LORD.

See the note on 1:6c–d. The same Hebrew word is translated as “reverence” here. If possible, use the same expression in both verses.

2:5d
and he revered Me

- And he did revere me
- Indeed, they did revere/honor me

he revered Me: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as revered is a different form of the same verb which was used in 2:5c. This repetition of the verb emphasizes it. In some languages it may be necessary to change the second expression in some way to make it natural. For example:

and of reverence, which he showed Me. (NJPS)

2:5e
and stood in awe of My name.

- and respected my-name/me.

stood in awe of My name: That is, he respected/feared me greatly. Here again, the subject of the verb is singular, but it refers to both Levi and his descendants.

My name: In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “the LORD’s name” or My name refers to God himself or his authority. Baldwin (1972), page 225; Merrill (1994), page 401. It was also used in this way in 1:6. See the note on 1:6f. GNT uses “me” instead of My name to make this clear.

General Comment on 2:5d–e

These two verse parts are parallel and have similar meanings:

he revered Me,

and stood in awe of My name.

Malachi 2:6

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 2:5–7

The Hebrew text uses singular pronouns in 2:5–7 which refer back to Levi. However the reference here is not to Levi himself. It refers to his descendants, the priests of earlier days, who obeyed the LORD. GNT uses the plural form in this paragraph and in the following verses to indicate that the verses refer to more than one person. Similarly, the NCV translates this reference to Levi in 2:5 as:

My agreement for priests was with the tribe of Levi. (NCV)

You should consider if you should do the same in your translation. Make sure that you are consistent in your use of singular or plural pronouns in this section.

2:6

his: In this verse the Hebrew forms which the BSB translates as his continue to refer to Levi and his descendants, especially to those who were priests.

2:6a

True instruction was in his mouth,

- He taught the people the truth,
- They taught Yahweh's laws to the people correctly,

True instruction: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates here as instruction refers to what the priests taught the people about God's law. This was one of their responsibilities.

True: The priests taught the people God's law in an accurate way. They told the truth about what was written in the law.

in his mouth: In Hebrew the expression which the BSB translates as in his mouth is a poetic way to refer to the words/teachings of the priests. For example:

They taught the true teachings. (NCV)

2:6b

and nothing false was found on his lips.

- and he did not teach any evil.
- and they did not teach lies.

nothing false was found on his lips: That is, he never said/spoke anything evil or untrue.

on his lips: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as on his lips is similar to the phrase "in his

mouth" in 2:6a. It is another poetic way to refer to the words of Levi and his descendants.

General Comment on 2:6a–b

These two verse parts are parallel. Notice the use of positive and negative terms: true instruction and nothing false (speech).

True instruction was in his mouth,

and nothing false was found on his lips.

2:6c

He walked with Me in peace and uprightness,

- He walked closely with me and lived in well-being and integrity
- They lived in fellowship with me, lived in peace and did what was right.

He walked with Me: This is a figure of speech in Hebrew. "To walk with someone" in this figurative sense means "to live in harmony with someone," "to live in close fellowship." Baldwin (1972), page 235.

peace: See the note on 2:5a.

uprightness: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as uprightness can also mean "integrity, loyalty, honesty." NJPS interprets shalom in the sense of "integrity" and compresses the parallelism into "complete loyalty."

One way to express this without using a noun is to say, "they always did what was right."

2:6d

and he turned many from iniquity.

- and he also turned many people away from their sins
- They also caused many people to change their behavior and stop sinning.

he turned many from iniquity: This is a figure of speech. The early descendants of Levi obeyed the LORD and accurately explained his laws to the people. This caused many people to change the way they behaved—they stopped sinning and began to obey the LORD.

Malachi 2:7

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

Paragraph 2:5–7

The Hebrew text uses singular pronouns in 2:5–7 which refer back to Levi. However the reference here is not to Levi himself. It refers to his descendants, the priests of

earlier days, who obeyed the LORD. GNT uses the plural form in this paragraph and in the following verses to indicate that the verses refer to more than one person. Similarly, the NCV translates this reference to Levi in 2:5 as:

My agreement for priests was with the tribe of Levi. (NCV)

You should consider if you should do the same in your translation. Make sure that you are consistent in your use of singular or plural pronouns in this section.

2:7a

For the lips of a priest should preserve knowledge,

- It is a priest's duty to preserve/guard the truth about Yahweh.

For: The Hebrew connector *ki* which the BSB translates as *For* seems to introduce a conclusion for this paragraph. It emphasizes the information about the early descendants of Levi. It also prepares the reader for the next paragraph which contrasts them with the evil priests of Malachi's time. Some English versions translate it as "for," and some omit it. Use what would be natural in your language for this context.

the lips of a priest should preserve knowledge: That is, a priest should speak accurately about the LORD so that the people will know the LORD and what is true about him.

preserve knowledge: To preserve knowledge means both to obey it and to cause others to know it. Redditt (1995), page 169.

2:7b

and people should seek instruction from his mouth,

- People should go to him and ask him to instruct/teach them how to please Yahweh,

people should seek instruction from his mouth: That is, people should go to a priest to learn what to do to please the LORD.

instruction: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as *instruction* is the same word that was used in 2:6a. In Malachi it usually refers to teaching about God's law.

General Comment on 2:6a–7b

In these verses there are parallel ideas that are arranged in a pattern called a "chiasm."

1. True instruction was in his mouth, (2:6a)
2. and nothing false was found on his lips. (2:6b)

3. He walked with Me in peace and uprightness, and he turned many from iniquity. (2:6c–d)

- (B') For the lips of a priest should preserve knowledge, (2:7a)
- (A') and people should seek instruction from his mouth. (2:7b)

Notice that the ideas in phrases A and A' are parallel, and the ideas in phrases B and B' are parallel.

2:7c

because he is the messenger of the LORD of Hosts.

- because he is a messenger of Yahweh Sabaoth."

because: The word *because* in the BSB translates the same Hebrew connector *ki* which was used in 2:7a. Here it introduces the reason for 2:7a–b. English versions translate it as *because* or "for." Use what would be natural in your language to express this idea.

the messenger: The Hebrew word *malak* which the BSB translates as *messenger* is, of course, a key word in the book of Malachi. It is used elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible to describe prophets, but only here does it refer to priests.

the LORD of Hosts: See the notes on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

Malachi 2:8

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

2:8a

But you have departed from the way,

- ¶ "But you^(plur) no longer follow me/my instructions.
- ¶ "But you^(plur) priests have turned away from me and no longer follow my instructions/law.

But you: These words contrast the priests of Malachi's time with their ancestors. The behavior of these priests, as described in 2:8, was the opposite of the priests described in 2:5–6.

In 2:6 they

walked with me;

in 2:8 they

departed from the way.

Also, in 2:6 they

turned many from iniquity;

in 2:8 they

caused many to stumble.

the way: Here the way refers to the correct way to behave, the way the LORD told them to behave and perform their duties. Here it is described figuratively as if it were a path.

2:8b

and your instruction has caused many to stumble.

- You^(plur) teach people things/lies that cause many to go astray from me/my teachings,
- What you^(plur) teach causes people to sin,

your instruction has caused many to stumble: That is, “your teaching has caused many people to go astray” or “you teach people things that cause many to go astray.”

instruction: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as instruction is the same word that was used in 2:6a and 2:7b. In Malachi it usually refers to the priests’ duties in teaching the people about God’s law. However if the priests did not teach the truth about God’s law, the people would not obey him properly.

to stumble: This is a figurative expression which implies, “to depart from my commands.”

2:8c

You have violated the covenant of Levi,”

- and you^(plur) have broken/violated the covenant that I made with Levi your^(plur) ancestor.”

You have violated the covenant of Levi: That is, you have spoilt/corrupted/broken the covenant that I made with Levi.

the covenant of Levi: This covenant also included Levi’s descendants.

2:8d

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:6e.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

Malachi 2:9

Section 1:6–2:9: The LORD rebuked the priests

2:9a

“So I in turn have made you despised and humiliated before all the people,

- “Therefore I will cause you^(plur) to be regarded as worthless by all the people of Israel and you will be humiliated before them all
- “Therefore I will cause all the people of Israel to despise you and they will see your^(sing) shame when I humble you.

So: The Hebrew particle w- used here introduces the result of the priests’ disobeying the LORD (2:8).

I in turn have made you despised and humiliated before all the people: This may be translated as, “I will cause all the people of Israel to despise you and regard you as being worthless.”

despised: There is an implied passive idea here. This is the same verb used in 1:6f, 1:7c and 1:12c. The priests had despised the LORD and the sacrifices which they should be making to him. In the same way, the LORD would cause them to be despised by other people.

humiliated: This is also an implied passive. The priests would be considered humiliated by other people. That is, people were going to consider the priests to be vile, to have a shameful character.

There are at least two possibilities for translating these two verbs:

- Keep the implied passive. For example:

I...have made you contemptible and vile to the whole people. (NJB)

- Make the idea active with a subject like “people.” For example:

I...will make the people of Israel despise you. (GNT)

Use an option which is natural in your language to express the meaning.

2:9b

because you have not kept My ways,

- because you^(plur) did not follow my instructions/laws,
- I will do this because you^(plur) did not do what I told you^(plur) to do,

because: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as because means “to the extent that.” Here

it compares 2:9a with 2:9b. The LORD will cause the priests to be despised to the extent that they have not kept his ways and have shown partiality in their instruction. In this verse, the expression acts like a reason connector.

Use what would be natural in your language in this context.

you have not kept My ways: That is, you have not obeyed my instructions/laws. The same Hebrew word for ways was used in 2:8a.

2:9c

but have shown partiality in matters of the law.”

- but instead you^(plur) are unfair in the way you^(plur) apply my law.”
- and you^(plur) have not treated people fairly/alike as you^(plur) were instructing them about my law.”

but have shown partiality in matters of the law: This part of the verse indicates that the priests were unfair to certain people in the way that they applied the law of God when they made decisions. For example, as priests, they decided whether an animal was too blemished to be acceptable for sacrifice. When they made such decisions, they treated some people better than others. Some ways to express this in English are:

You have been unfair when applying my teachings. (GW)

you...have shown partiality in your interpretation of the law. (NLT)

you...show partiality in your rulings. (NJPS)

matters of the law: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as matters of the law is the same word that was translated as “instruction” in 2:6a, 2:7b, 2:8b. Here it refers specifically to the way that the priests interpreted God’s law as they made decisions that affected people’s lives.

Malachi 2:10

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.
3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means “faithless, treacherous” occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

2:10

As stated in the introduction to this section, in this verse and those following, it is the prophet himself who was speaking. The content of 2:10 makes this clear.

However there is no marker in Hebrew to indicate that it is no longer the LORD who was speaking (1:2–2:9) but Malachi. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit in some way. There are at least three possibilities:

- Indicate it in the section heading, as the section heading in these Notes has done:

Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD.

- Use a footnote to explain that 2:10–15 are the words of Malachi.
- Make it explicit in the text. For example, you could begin 2:10 with a phrase like:

These are the words of Malachi:

I, Malachi, ask you:

Malachi said:

Use the option which is most appropriate in your language.

2:10a

Do we not all have one Father?

- ¶ Do we^(incl) not all have one father?
- ¶ We^(incl) the people of Israel all have one father, do we^(incl) not?
- ¶ You^(plur) know that we^(incl) all have one father, Yahweh,

Do we not all have one Father?: Here we refers to the people of Israel, not to human beings in general. Baldwin (1972), page 237; Merrill (1994), page 414; Redditt (1995), page 170. Malachi identified himself with the rest of the people of Israel when he used the pronoun we here.

This is the first rhetorical question which Malachi himself used. He wanted to emphasize what he was saying by asserting something that his hearers all knew to be true. The question expects the answer “yes.” If you do not use rhetorical questions like this in your language, you can reword it as a strong positive statement. Here is one example:

You know that we all have one Father.

one Father: This refers to God. Some commentators argue that “one father” may refer to Abraham (Baldwin 1972, page 237), or Jacob, or even to Levi. The evidence for interpreting the reference to be to God is, however, convincing: (a) God has already been referred to as “father” in 1:6. (b) “father” is parallel with “God” in the parallelism: have we not all one father? has not one God created us? This is also consistent with other Scriptures where the parallel ideas of God as Father and Creator are found (Deuteronomy 32:6). See further the discussion in Keil and Delitzsch (1950), page 448, and Merrill (1994), page 414, also Redditt (1995), page 170. The CEV makes this explicit:

Don't you know that we all have God as our Father? (CEV)

2:10b

Did not one God create us?

- Did not one God create us^(incl)?
- The same God created us^(incl) all, did he not?
- and you^(plur) know that the same God, Yahweh, created us^(incl) all.

Did not one God create us?: This is Malachi's second rhetorical question and again it expects the answer “yes.” One way to express this as a positive statement would be:

You know that the same God created us.

General Comment on 2:10a–b

Notice that 2:10a and 2:10b say almost the same thing. The ideas are also arranged in a special pattern called a “chiasm.”

Do we not all have one Father?

Did not one God create us?

The parallelism and the chiasm indicate that these verse parts express an important idea in the text.

2:10c–d

Scholars interpret the connection between 2:10c and 2:10d in at least three ways:

1. The statement in 2:10d explains the result of the people's unfaithfulness to each other in 2:10c. They were unfaithful to each other, and, as a result, they profaned the covenant. For example:

Why do we deal treacherously each against his brother so as to profane the covenant of our fathers? (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NET, NASB)

1. The statements in 2:10c and 2:10d are two different ways that the people were displeasing God. For example:

Then why do we break our promises to one another, and why do we despise the covenant that God made with our ancestors? (GNT) (GNT, GW, NCV)

1. The statement in 2:10d indicates the way that the people had been unfaithful. They had been unfaithful by profaning the covenant. For example:

Then why do you cheat each other by breaking the agreement God made with your ancestors? (CEV) (CEV, KJV, REB)

Some English versions are ambiguous about the connection. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

See also the general comment on 2:10c–d for a reordering suggestion.

2:10c

Why then do we break faith with one another

- Then why do we^(incl) betray one another,
- But we^(incl) still are unfaithful to each other,

Why then do we break faith with one another...?:

That is, why do we (the people of Israel) not keep our commitments and promises to one another? This rhetorical question introduces the following verses, which describe ways that the people of Israel had been unfaithful to God's commands. They had also been unfaithful to each other, especially in breaking their marriage vows.

then: The BSB has included the word then to show the relationship between 2:10c and the preceding questions in 2:10a–b. Those questions imply that the people should have been united because God was the father and creator of all of them. However 2:10c states that instead they were unfaithful to each other. Malachi did not expect them to act that way.

In some languages it may be necessary to make the expectation explicit. Languages have different ways to show that something was different from what the speaker expected. Here are some possibilities for translation:

- Use a connector which implies this. For example:

So why do people break their promises to each other...? (NCV)

- Refer to the preceding question to show the connection. For example:

Since that is true, why are we unfaithful to each other?

- Make Malachi's expectation explicit. For example:

Because of this, you should have been faithful to each other. Why have you been unfaithful instead...?

Use the option which is most appropriate in your language.

break faith: The Hebrew word bagad which the BSB translates as break faith is the key word in this section. See the discussion at the beginning of Section

2:10–16. This word describes the way the people of Israel behaved in all their relationships:

1. they broke their promises to each other (2:10),
2. they broke their promises to their wives (2:14–15) and
3. they broke their covenant with God himself (2:11).

2:10d

so as to profane the covenant of our fathers?

- and so break the covenant that Yahweh made with our^(incl) ancestors?
- and as a result, we^(incl) violate/disobey/disregard the covenant which Yahweh made with our^(incl) ancestors?
- and by this unfaithfulness, we^(incl) break the covenant that Yahweh made with our^(incl) ancestors!

so as to profane the covenant of our fathers: This statement explains the result of 2:10c. When the people were unfaithful to each other, they profaned the covenant.

profane: That is, disregard/disobey/violate.

the covenant of our fathers: This refers to the covenant which God made with the ancestors of the people of Israel. It may be necessary to make this explicit in some translations. This has been done in 2:10d in the Display.

General Comment on 2:10c–d

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of these verse parts. Notice that it may be necessary then to use a different connector between 2:10c and 2:10d. For example:

^{10d}Why do we profane the covenant of our fathers
^{10c}by breaking faith with one another? (NIV)

Malachi 2:11

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.

3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means “faithless, treacherous” occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

2:11a

Judah has broken faith;

- We,^(incl) the people of Judah, have not been faithful to Yahweh.

Judah has broken faith: That is, the descendants of Judah had broken their promise to God to obey and serve him only. They had worshipped other gods (idols). The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as has broken faith is the same verb (*bagad*) which was used in 2:10 to describe the people’s unfaithfulness to each other.

Judah: Here Judah is another way to refer to people who were descendants of Judah’s father, Israel (who was also called Jacob).

2:11b

an abomination has been committed in Israel and in Jerusalem.

- A revolting/disgusting thing has been done in Jerusalem and in the land of Israel.
- We,^(incl) have done something that is revolting/disgusting in the city of Jerusalem and in the rest of Israel.

an abomination has been committed: That is, a terrible, disgusting thing has been done. If you need to use an active verb you could say: “The people have done a terrible thing.”

in Israel: This refers to the land of Israel.

in Jerusalem: The city of Jerusalem was in the land of Israel. In some languages it may be better to mention it before Israel is mentioned, as, for example:

in the city of Jerusalem and in the whole region of Israel.

2:11c

For Judah has profaned the LORD’s beloved sanctuary

- That is, we^(incl) have defiled the temple of Yahweh, which he loves

For: The Hebrew word *ki* which the BSB translates as For has many uses. Here it introduces a specific act that was part of the general action which Malachi mentioned in 2:11b. There he said that an abomination had been committed; in this part of the verse he explained what the abomination was. Express this connection in an appropriate way in your language.

Judah has profaned: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as has profaned is the same verb which was used in 1:12a and 2:10d. Here its use is similar to 1:12a, where it means to “dishonor, treat as unholy/common.”

the LORD’s beloved sanctuary: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as sanctuary is the noun *qodeš*. This literally means “holiness.” Here most English versions agree that it refers to the temple, the sanctuary of the LORD. Commentators have suggested four main interpretations: (1) It refers to the sanctuary of the LORD. This is the view followed by most English versions. It is also supported by Redditt (1995), pages 170–171; Smith 1984, pages 319, 322, Glazier-McDonald 1987, pages 90–91. (2) *qodeš* refers to God’s chosen people, the people of Israel. They are also called the “holy seed/race” in Ezra 9:2 and Isaiah 6:13. The people of Israel had profaned their nation by marrying foreign wives and by failing to keep their marriage vows to their wives. This fits the immediate context well, and has a similar meaning to the parallel passage in Ezra. Ezra chapters 9 and 10 and Nehemiah 13:23–29 make it clear that marriage with women who worshiped foreign gods was a serious problem in Israel at that time. Marriage with such women is strongly forbidden in a number of places in Scripture. See, for example, Exodus 34:15–16, Deuteronomy 7:3–4, also 2 Cor. 6:14–15. This interpretation is discussed by Baldwin (1972) pages 238–239, Dods (1990) page 143, Keil and Delitzsch (1950), page 449, and Lange (1960), page 16. (3) A third interpretation is that the “holiness” of Yahweh refers here to the covenant, picking up the reference to the covenant in the previous verse (Merrill 1994, page 418). (4) Yet another interpretation is that ‘the holiness of Yahweh’ might also refer to the essential holiness of Yahweh, his ‘apartness’ from anything we ourselves know by experience. In this

case the profaning would consist of treating God as something common, considering his holiness to be unimportant. This is supported by Hill, pages 230–1.

the LORD's beloved: That is, which the LORD loves.

2:11d

by marrying the daughter of a foreign god.

- and have married women who worship foreign gods.
- and have married women who worship idols.

by marrying the daughter of a foreign god: Again scholars suggest different meanings for this part of the verse: The debate on the meaning of 'daughter of a foreign god' has been extensive. The main question has been whether this phrase is figurative, and refers to the fact that the nation of Israel was itself involved in pagan worship, or whether it is literal, and refers to the fact that they are marrying pagan women, who worshipped idols. Glazier-McDonald (1987 ⁽²⁾) argues that both meanings are meant by Malachi, and that one is incomplete without the other. See also the articles by Ogden (1988) and Clark (1998).

1. It means "you have married women who worship other gods." For example:

the men of Judah married women who worship foreign gods. (NCV) (GNT, NCV, NLT, GW)

1. It means "you have turned to worship a foreign god." This uses the metaphor of adultery to describe the way the people of Israel were being unfaithful to the LORD. This is a common metaphor in the OT. For example:

For Judah has...turned to a foreign god! (NET)
(NET, CEV)

Many English versions are ambiguous here. However it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits well with the context in 2:10–11.

daughter: This word is used in a collective sense here. The meaning is plural, that is, women.

Malachi 2:12

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.
3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means "faithless, treacherous" occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

2:12a

As for the man who does this, may the LORD cut off from the tents of Jacob everyone who is awake and aware—

- May Yahweh separate/remove any person who does such things, whoever he may be, so that he is separated forever from the descendants of Jacob,

In this verse Malachi expressed a strong desire or prayer. He wanted the LORD to punish all Israelite men who married women who worshipped other gods.

As for the man who does this, may the LORD cut off from the tents of Jacob everyone who is awake and aware: Scholars disagree about the type of punishment that Malachi meant here. The Hebrew text of this verse is hard to understand. There are two main interpretations:

1. Malachi meant that the LORD should remove all such men from the community of Israel. For example:

As for the man who does this, whoever he may be, may the Lord cut him off from the tents of Jacob... (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, KJV, NLT, NCV, NET, REB)

1. Malachi meant that the LORD should not allow such men to have anyone to defend or support them. For example:

May Yahweh deprive such an offender of witness and advocate... (NJB) (NJB, RSV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

the man who does this: This refers to any Israelite man who married a woman who worshipped idols. It includes those who had already done it and those who would do it in the future.

cut off: The expression which the BSB translates as cut off is an idiom in Hebrew. Here it means “remove,” that is, the LORD should remove them from the Israelite community. The Hebrew text does not state how he would remove them: whether he would banish them or kill them. You should also leave this ambiguous. Some ways to say this are:

May the Lord remove from the community of Israel those who did this. (GNT)

May the Lord banish from the dwellings of Jacob any who do this. (REB)

I pray that the Lord will no longer let those who are guilty belong to his people. (CEV)

from the tents of Jacob: This is an idiom which refers to all the people of Israel. They were the people who had a covenant relationship with the LORD and who worshipped him. The reference to tents came from the time when the descendants of Jacob/Israel, the people of Israel, lived in tents and wandered in the desert.

everyone who is awake and aware: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as everyone who is awake and aware is difficult to understand. Scholars make two main suggestions Clark (1998) gives an excellent review of the alternative possible interpretations here. See also Alden (1985), page 718; Dods (1990), page 143; Merrill (1994), page 419; Redditt (1995), pages 171–172. Yet another alternative but less likely interpretation, is ‘May the LORD cut off from Israel anyone who defends the ones guilty of marrying foreign wives.’ about its meaning in this verse:

1. The two Hebrew words which the BSB translates as awake and aware function together as a Hebrew idiom, which, means “everyone.” From this inter-

pretation comes “whoever they may be.” So the meaning of 2:12a is:

May the LORD drive away those who marry foreign wives, whoever they may be, so that they may never again be part of Israel. (BSB, NIV, GNT, GW, NCV, NET, NLT)

1. The two words have separate meanings and represent two groups of people or two different actions. The English versions that follow this view interpret the individual words differently. Baldwin (1972) page 239. For example:

...witness and advocate. (NJB) (RSV, NJB, KJV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

2:12b

even if he brings an offering to the LORD of Hosts.

- even if he were to bring/offer any gift/sacrifice to Yahweh Sabaoth.
- may Yahweh Sabaoth remove him without considering any gift/sacrifice he might bring to him!

even if he brings an offering to the LORD of Hosts:

Scholars differ about how this phrase relates to the previous one. There are at least three views:

1. This phrase makes it clear that there is no exception to the punishment in 2:12a. Even offering a sacrifice to the LORD would not enable them to escape this punishment. For example:

[May the LORD banish from the dwellings of Jacob any who do this...] even though they bring offerings to the Lord of Hosts. (REB) (BSB, NIV, REB, CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. This phrase expresses part of the punishment that Malachi spoke about in 2:12a. For example:

and never again let them participate in the offerings our nation brings to the Lord Almighty. (GNT) (GNT, NJB, GW)

1. This phrase goes with the preceding phrase “any to witness or answer.” It lists another group of people or another action. For example:

[any to witness or answer,] or to bring an offering to the Lord of hosts! (RSV) (RSV, KJV, NASB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

In English this idea is often expressed by using connectors like “even though” or “and yet.” Express it in a natural way in your language.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d and 1:6e. Translate this term in the same way here.

Malachi 2:13

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.
3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means “faithless, treacherous” occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

Paragraph 2:13–16

Paragraph 2:10–12 shows that the people were unfaithful to the LORD and unfaithful to his covenant because they had married women who worshipped foreign gods (idols). Paragraph 2:13–16 tells another way that the people of Israel were unfaithful. They were also unfaithful to each other in marriage.

Notice the use of the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern, introducing a new discourse unit. See

note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

2:13a

And this is another thing you do:

- ¶ There is another evil thing that you^(plur) people of Israel do.

2:13b

You cover the altar of the LORD with tears, with weeping and groaning,

- You^(plur) stand at Yahweh’s altar, and you^(plur) weep and wail loudly before him/Yahweh,
- You^(plur) shed lots of tears when you^(plur) are at the altar where people sacrifice to Yahweh. You weep and wail loudly

You cover the altar of the LORD with tears, with weeping and groaning:

This is a figure of speech, a hyperbole. The people did not actually cover the altar with their tears. However they had wailed and cried loudly with much noise and emotion.

2:13c

because He no longer regards your offerings

- because he no longer receives/accepts the sacrifices/gifts you^(plur) bring him
- for he no longer looks with pleasure on your^(plur) sacrifices/gifts

He no longer regards your offerings: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as regards literally means “turns to.” Here it indicates that the LORD no longer considered their offerings to be worth anything.

2:13d

or receives them gladly from your hands.

- nor does he accept them from you^(plur) with favor.
- and what you^(plur) bring no longer pleases him.

from your hands: In this context, from your hands means “from you.” The same Hebrew expression was used in 1:9b, 1:10e and 1:13f.

General Comment on 2:13c–d

Notice that these two verse parts are parallel:

He no longer regards your offerings

or receives them gladly from your hands.

Malachi 2:14

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.
3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means “faithless, treacherous” occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

Paragraph 2:13–16

Paragraph 2:10–12 shows that the people were unfaithful to the LORD and unfaithful to his covenant because they had married women who worshipped foreign gods (idols). Paragraph 2:13–16 tells another way that the people of Israel were unfaithful. They were also unfaithful to each other in marriage.

Notice the use of the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern, introducing a new discourse unit. See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

2:14

you...you...your...you...: The first you in this verse translates a plural form in Hebrew. As in 2:13, this form refers to the people of Israel. However the other forms which the BSB translates as you in 2:14 are singular. They refer to each individual man who had been un-

faithful. The Display indicates this by the phrase “each of you” in 2:14b.

2:14a

Yet you ask, “Why?”

- You^(plur) ask, “Why do our^(excl) sacrifices not please Yahweh any longer?”

Why?: That is, why does the LORD not accept our sacrifices?

2:14b

It is because the LORD has been a witness between you and the wife of your youth,

- It is because Yahweh heard the promises/vows each of you^(plur) made when you^(sing) were young and married your^(sing) wife.

witness: The text does not specify exactly how the LORD was a witness between a person and the wife of his youth. The most likely meaning is that the LORD was a witness to their covenant of marriage. Therefore the LORD was responsible to punish the men who broke their marriage covenants. He punished them by not accepting their offerings.

the wife of your youth: That is, the wife you married when you were young.

2:14c

against whom you have broken faith,

- But you^(sing) have not kept those promises to her,
- But you^(sing) have not been faithful/loyal to her, as you^(sing) promised to be,

you have broken faith: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as broken faith is the same one used in 2:10–11. It is the key term in this section. See the note on 2:10c. Husbands were being unfaithful to their wives. In this way, they were not keeping the promises they had made to their wives at their marriage.

2:14d

though she is your companion

- even though she has been your^(sing) partner.
- even though she has stayed with you^(sing).

your companion: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as companion means here “a female companion in marriage.” It is a synonym of “wife.”

2:14e

and your wife by covenant.

- You^(sing) have done this even though you^(sing) had promised/agreed with her that she would always be your^(sing) wife.

covenant: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as covenant is the same word used in 2:4b and 2:10d. This word is normally used in the Old Testament to refer to the relationship the LORD established at Sinai between himself and the people of Israel.

Here it refers to marriage and the promises which a man and woman make to be faithful to each other. In many languages it may be appropriate to use a word like “promise” or “vow” here. This may be better than the word used for the covenant between the LORD and the people of Israel.

Malachi 2:15

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.
3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means “faithless, treacherous” occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

Paragraph 2:13–16

Paragraph 2:10–12 shows that the people were unfaithful to the LORD and unfaithful to his covenant because they had married women who worshipped foreign gods (idols). Paragraph 2:13–16 tells another way that

the people of Israel were unfaithful. They were also unfaithful to each other in marriage.

Notice the use of the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern, introducing a new discourse unit. See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

2:15a

Has not the LORD made them one,

- Did not Yahweh make you^(sing) and your^(sing) wife one when you married? Yes, he did.
- You^(sing) know that Yahweh united you^(sing) and your^(sing) wife as one person.

Has not the LORD made them one...?: Scholars do not agree about the meaning of this part of the verse because the Hebrew grammar is unclear. The meaning which scholars choose mainly depends on how they interpret the Hebrew word for one:

1. The word one refers to the bond between a husband and wife that is formed when they marry each other. The implied subject can be expressed as “God” or the LORD. For example:

Didn't the Lord make you one with your wife? (NLT)
(BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. The word one refers to God, so it is the subject of the verb made. English versions that follow this interpretation supply the word “God” or capitalize the word one to clarify that it refers to God. For example:

Has not the one God made... (RSV)NET Bible offers an alternative interpretation: ‘No one does this who has even a small portion of the Spirit in him.’ It interprets the following statement to refer to the example of Abraham’s union with Hagar as a warning. (RSV, NJPS, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits the context well and it is an acceptable way to interpret the Hebrew grammar here. Also many scholars support it. From this point onwards in the Notes, this interpretation is assumed.

General Comment on 2:15a

This is a rhetorical question with the implied answer, “Yes, of course he did.” If your language would not use a rhetorical question in this way, it may be best to use an emphatic statement. For example:

God made husbands and wives to become one body and one spirit... (NCV)

2:15b

having a portion of the Spirit?

- Your^(plur) body and spirit belong to him.
- Your^(plur) united body and spirit are for him.

having a portion of the Spirit?: Scholars do not agree about the meaning of the Hebrew text of this part of the verse either. They also connect 2:15a and 2:15b in different ways. There are many views, but the Notes will discuss only the most likely interpretations: Another view is that no one who has even a little of the Spirit of God would do such a thing. (NET, NASB)

1. It means that the flesh and spirit of a human and wife belong to the LORD. For example:

[Didn't the Lord make you one with your wife?] In body and spirit you are his. (NLT) (NIV, NRSV, NLT, NCV, GW)

1. It means that the LORD made a husband and his wife become one in both flesh and spirit. It does not explicitly state that flesh and spirit belong to him. For example:

Didn't God create you to become like one person with your wife? (CEV) (GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. It means that the LORD made the human spirit. There are different variations of this view. Some scholars believe that the text refers to both flesh and spirit. Others believe that it refers to the spirit of life. For example:

Did he not create a single being, having flesh and the breath of life? (NJB) (RSV, NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This view fits with the LORD's aim (2:15c) that husband and wife should have godly offspring. So the Display will use the NLT as the Source Line for 2:15b.

General Comment on 2:15a–b

In Hebrew there are no pronouns in this part of the verse. Malachi was expressing a general fact about marriage that applies to every husband and wife. The NLT uses the pronouns "you," "your," and "you" to indicate this general reference. In some languages

it may be more natural to use different pronouns or nouns to express this fact. For example:

Has not the Lord made them one? In flesh and spirit they are his. (NIV)

Didn't the LORD make husbands and wives one? In body and spirit they are his.

2:15c

And why one?

- Why did he unite you^(sing) and your^(sing) wife like this?
- What was his purpose/desire in making you^(plur) one?

And why one?: Scholars disagree about what this verse part means also. It is likely that Malachi was introducing God's purpose in uniting husbands and wives. English versions express this meaning in different ways: For example:

What was his purpose in this? (GNT)

And what does he want? (NLT)

This verse part is another rhetorical question. Its purpose is to introduce a new point. If you would not use a rhetorical question in that way in your language, it may be best to use a statement.

2:15d

Because He seeks godly offspring.

- He did this because he wants you^(plur) to have children who will follow/obey/respect him.

Because He seeks godly offspring: The text refers here to children that a faithful husband and "the wife of your youth" (2:14b, 15f) may have. It is more likely that children who are raised by godly parents will follow and obey God.

2:15e

So guard yourselves in your spirit

- Therefore watch yourselves^(plur),
- Therefore, be careful how you^(plur) behave,

So: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as So is the conjunction w-. Here it introduces a statement about the way the people should act to please God and fulfill his desire for godly offspring.

2:15f

and do not break faith with the wife of your youth.

- and let none of you^(plur) be unfaithful/disloyal to the wife whom he married when he was young.

- and let none of you^(plur) break the promise that he made to the wife whom he married when he was young.

break faith with: This is the same word which was used in 2:10, 11, 14. See the notes on 2:10c and 2:14c.

the wife of your youth: See the note on 2:14b.

Malachi 2:16

Section 2:10–16: Malachi rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD

This section contains the central message of the book. It highlights its main theme: that is, that both the priests and the people had been unfaithful to the LORD. The LORD here called them to repent and to follow him again.

This section lists three specific ways in which the people of Israel as a nation had broken their covenant with the LORD:

1. They had married wives who worshipped foreign gods.
2. They had been unfaithful to their wives.
3. They had even divorced their wives.

Also the people had been hypocritical. They asked the LORD to help them in order to show that they trusted him. Yet, at the same time, they continued to be unfaithful to him and to disobey him.

The Hebrew word *bagad* which means “faithless, treacherous” occurs five times in these verses. The repeated use of the word highlights both the unfaithfulness of the people to the LORD and their unfaithfulness to their wives.

This section contains one of the few places in the book in which it was the prophet himself who addressed the people. The prophet rebuked the people of Israel because they had been unfaithful to the LORD. He began his rebuke with a series of rhetorical questions. The first two questions in this section form a doublet, which makes an emphatic beginning, and all the questions indicate strong feeling.

Paragraph 2:13–16

Paragraph 2:10–12 shows that the people were unfaithful to the LORD and unfaithful to his covenant because they had married women who worshipped foreign gods (idols). Paragraph 2:13–16 tells another way that the people of Israel were unfaithful. They were also unfaithful to each other in marriage.

Notice the use of the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern, introducing a new discourse unit. See

note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

2:16

The prophet stopped speaking his own words in 2:15, and in 2:16 the LORD once again spoke directly to the people.

2:16a

“For I hate divorce,”

- “I am displeased when a man divorces his wife,”
- “I hate it when people divorce each other,”

For: The Hebrew connector *ki* introduces the reason for the command in 2:15. However it can be difficult to translate here because it connects the LORD’s own words with what the prophet had been saying. The meaning is that the people should not be unfaithful to their wives because the LORD hates divorce. In some languages this connection may be implied without a connector. If that is true in your language, you can omit it, as many English versions do. For example:

The Lord God of Israel says, “I hate divorce.” (NCV)

I hate divorce: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as divorce literally means “sending away.” Some scholars interpret the implied subject of “hate” to be indefinite. This gives the sense “If anyone hating (his wife) divorces (her), says Yahweh the God of Israel, he covers his garment with violence.” REB “If a man divorces or puts away his wife, says the Lord God of Israel, he overwhelms her with cruelty.” Pohl (1998) gives arguments in support of this interpretation. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb phrase rather than a noun to express the action of divorce. For example:

I hate it when a man divorces his wife.

When a man and his wife divorce, I hate that.

Use an expression which is natural in your language.

2:16b

says the LORD, the God of Israel.

- says Yahweh, the God of Israel,
- Yahweh, the God of Israel, says to you^(plur),

says the LORD, the God of Israel: There is a change of speaker in 2:16. In some languages it may be necessary to begin the verse with the speech clause to make this clear. See the example from the NCV in 2:16a.

the LORD, the God of Israel: Notice that the longer title for God is used here. This emphasizes the fact that the LORD had started speaking again. It also highlights the importance and authority of the statement.

2:16c

“He who divorces his wife covers his garment with violence,”

- “and I hate it when anyone is violent/cruel towards his wife by divorcing her.”

He who divorces his wife covers his garment with violence: Scholars do not agree about the meaning of the Hebrew text here. English versions have translated it in different ways. There are many views, but the Notes will discuss only the three which seem most accepted:

1. It refers to divorce as being cruel towards a person's wife. A garment may be a symbol for the wife. “Garment” is an Arabic idiom for a man's wife. So covering one's garment may possibly be a figure of speech referring to marriage. However, there are no other apparent examples of the use of this idiom in Biblical Hebrew. For example:

I hate divorce...I hate it when one of you does such a cruel thing to his wife. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NLT, REB, CEV)

1. It refers to cruel actions which affect or indicate a person's own character. These actions might not be limited to divorce. For example:

I hate divorce...and the one who is guilty of violence. (NET) (NIV, NET, GW, NCV, NJPS)

1. It means to do violent or cruel actions and conceal them in some way. The garment would be a symbol for concealment. For example:

For I hate divorce...and people concealing their cruelty under a cloak. (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In many languages the figure of a garment may be confusing. If that is true in your language, it may be best to drop the figure and translate the meaning directly. See GNT example under option (1).

2:16d

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaoth.
- Yahweh Sabaoth has spoken.

- This is what Yahweh Sabaoth says to you^(plur).

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 1:4d, 1:6e and 2:12b.

2:16e

So guard yourselves in your spirit

- “Therefore watch yourselves^(plur).
- “Therefore, be careful how you^(plur) behave.

So guard yourselves in your spirit: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as So guard yourselves in your spirit is identical to the one used in 2:15e.

2:16f

and do not break faith.

- and do not fail to keep your^(plur) promise to be faithful/loyal to your^(plur) wife.”

and do not break faith: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as break faith is the same one which was used in 2:15f. The meaning of these verse parts is also the same, though 2:16f does not explicitly mention “the wife of your youth.”

General Comments on 2:16a–f

Scholars do not agree about where the LORD's direct words end. There are two main possibilities:

1. The LORD's words continue to the end of the verse. (GNT, RSV, NET, NLT, NASB, GW)
2. The LORD's words end at 2:16c and the words in 2:16e–f are the words of Malachi. (BSB, NIV, NCV)

In some English versions the punctuation system leaves this ambiguous (NJB, REB, CEV, NJPS).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Although parts of this section are difficult to understand, the main message is clear. The message is that divorce is an act of unfaithfulness, another example of breaking a covenant.

This statement in 2:16e–f summarizes the theme of the section, and of the whole book, again. It gives a warning to those who fail to keep a commitment. This summary marks the end of this section.

Malachi 2:17

Section 2:17–3:5: The LORD revealed that he would come to judge and purify his people

2:17 is a transitional verse. In 2:10–16 Malachi and the LORD listed ways that the priests and people had been unfaithful. In 2:17, the focus becomes the LORD's response to this unfaithfulness. So it seems best to

consider 2:17 as the beginning of a new section, rather than as the end of the preceding section.

Notice also that this verse contains Malachi's typical structure for beginning a new section:

1. a statement by the LORD,
2. a question challenging the LORD's statement,
3. and then the development of the theme of the section.

See note 6 in "Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi" in the Introduction.

2:17a

You have wearied the LORD with your words;

- ¶ Your^(plur) talking has wearied Yahweh completely.
- ¶ You^(plur) have said things that displeased Yahweh so that he is tired of being patient with you^(plur).

You have wearied the LORD: The LORD was displeased with what the people were saying, and he was tired of being patient with them.

with your words: This refers to what the people had said. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb phrase here. For example:

You have said things that make the LORD weary.

2:17b

yet you ask, "How have we wearied Him?"

- But you^(plur) say, "What have we^(excl) said to make him weary?"
- But you^(plur) ask, "How have we^(excl) made him tired of being patient with us?^(excl)"

2:17c

By saying,

- You^(plur) have wearied him when you^(plur) said,
- You^(plur) have done this by saying

By saying: This is an ellipsis. In some languages it may be necessary to supply the information which is implied. For example:

You did it by saying, "The Lord thinks anyone who does evil is good..." (NCV)

2:17d

"All who do evil are good in the sight of the LORD,

- "People who do evil are considered good people by Yahweh
- that Yahweh considers those who behave in an evil way to be good people,

All who do evil are good in the sight of the LORD:

These are words which challenge the LORD. The people were implying that the LORD was no longer behaving as he should. This challenge continues in 2:17e and 2:17f. In some languages it may be necessary to make this challenge explicit. For example:

You have wearied him by suggesting that the Lord favors evildoers since he does not punish them. (NLT)

2:17e

and in them He delights,"

- and he is pleased with them."
- and you^(plur) claim/teach that these people are his favorite ones."

2:17f

or, "Where is the God of justice?"

- You^(plur) also weary God when you^(plur) say/ask, "Why does God not judge these people?"
- You^(plur) also say, "God no longer punishes those who do wrong or rewards those who do right."

Where is the God of justice?: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as God of justice means "God who rules people fairly." It implies that he would reward people who do right and punish people who do evil.

This is a rhetorical question. It implies that God was not ruling fairly. In some languages it may be necessary to make this implied information explicit. For example:

Or by asking, "Where is the God who is supposed to be just?" (GNT)

Malachi 3:1

Section 2:17–3:5: The LORD revealed that he would come to judge and purify his people

2:17 is a transitional verse. In 2:10–16 Malachi and the LORD listed ways that the priests and people had been unfaithful. In 2:17, the focus becomes the LORD's response to this unfaithfulness. So it seems best to consider 2:17 as the beginning of a new section, rather than as the end of the preceding section.

Notice also that this verse contains Malachi's typical structure for beginning a new section:

1. a statement by the LORD,
2. a question challenging the LORD's statement,

3. and then the development of the theme of the section.

See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

3:1a

“Behold, I will send My messenger, who will prepare the way before Me.

- “Listen. I send my messenger who will prepare the way before I come.
- “Be warned. I will send my messenger and he will get things ready for my coming.

Behold: The Hebrew word *hinneh* which the BSB translates as *Behold* has the same function here as in 2:3a. It directs the reader’s attention to the statement that follows. This particle recurs later in this verse in 3:1e where it is translated as “see,” again highlighting an important statement.

I will send My messenger: This foretells an event which had not yet happened. See also Isaiah 40:3; Mark 1:2.

My messenger: The prophetic reference here is to John the Baptist. However you should not make this information explicit in your translation. See also Malachi 4:5, where the messenger is identified figuratively with Elijah the prophet.

who will prepare the way before Me: The purpose of the messenger’s coming was to get people ready for the arrival of the Lord. The messenger would tell them how to live in a way that would please the Lord.

The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as *prepare the way before Me* is used here in a figurative way. “Clearing the way before Yahweh’s epiphany means removing the “obstacles” of self-interest, spiritual lethargy, and evil behavior embedded in the people of God.” Hill (1998), page 267. In those times the roads were rough. It was sometimes necessary for messengers to go ahead of a king and prepare the road so that it would be possible for him to pass. In some languages this figure of speech may not be clear. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

to prepare people for my coming like men prepare the road for a king

before Me: That is, before the Lord.

3:1b

Then the Lord whom you seek

- Then the Lord, the one you^(plur) are looking/waiting for,
- Then your^(plur) Lord, about whom you^(plur) say, ‘Where is he?’

the Lord whom you seek: This is a reference to the coming Messiah—Jesus Christ. Alden (1985), Merrill (1994), page 431.

the Lord: The Hebrew word here is *ʾadon*, not *yhwh*. So make sure you use your normal translation of Lord here, not your term for Yahweh.

3:1c

will suddenly come to His temple—

- will appear suddenly in his temple.

3:1d

the Messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight—

- The messenger whom you^(plur) yearn/long to see, will proclaim my covenant.
- This messenger for whom you^(plur) look eagerly will come and announce my covenant with you^(plur).

the Messenger of the covenant: It is important to decide to whom the Messenger of the covenant here refers: There are two possible interpretations:

1. The Messenger of the covenant is the Lord in 3:1b. That is, it refers to the Messiah—Jesus Christ.
2. The Messenger of the covenant is the same person referred to as “my messenger” in 3:1a, and so refers to John the Baptist. Merrill (1994), pages 431–433.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

The parallelism between 3:1b–c and 3:1d–e supports this interpretation. The phrase the Messenger of the covenant is a title or description of this person. See the general comment about poetic parallelisms below. Also in support of this interpretation is the fact that elsewhere in Scripture, “the angel of the LORD” is the LORD himself in human form. The Hebrew word *malaʿ* may mean either “messenger” or “angel.” NJPS translates “the angel of the covenant” and a number of French translations also translate using the word for “angel.” In Exodus 3:2, the LORD speaks to Moses as the “angel of the LORD,” and affirms again that he has a special relationship with his people and that he will deliver them. Possibly Malachi may have in mind Exodus 3:2, and other references to the angel of the LORD, when he refers to the LORD as the messenger/angel of the covenant. Keil and Delitzsch (1950), page 458; Baldwin (1972), page 243.

Messenger of the covenant: This person would proclaim the message about the covenant.

Messenger: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as Messenger is the same word which occurred in 3:1a. It can refer to angels as well as human messengers. If it is possible to keep this ambiguity between “human messenger” and “angel” in your translation, do so. If that is not possible, you may wish to include a footnote saying that the words for “messenger” and “angel” are the same word in the original Hebrew text.

If you use a term for “messenger,” be careful not to use a word which would imply someone of low status, such as an errand boy or servant.

the covenant: Malachi was still referring primarily to the original covenant. Which covenant is referred to here? Unfortunately the commentators say little about this—Redditt doesn’t discuss it at all. Merrill seems to accept, without actually saying so, that it is the new covenant in view (and therefore presumably would agree with the GNT). Glazier-McDonald (1987⁽¹⁾) again doesn’t actually discuss it, but her description of the messenger as the “covenant-enforcer” seems to align with Keil and Delitzsch (1950). They alone discuss the question and see it as God’s covenant with Israel at Sinai, which the LORD made with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai. Scholars believe this for two reasons:

General Comments on 3:1b–d

1. He had already talked about that covenant in chapter 1 and did not indicate here that he was talking about a different covenant.
2. His hearers/readers would have automatically thought of this covenant. It was the only covenant of which they were aware.

In some languages it may be more natural to combine 3:1b, 3:1c and 3:1d. For example:

Suddenly the Lord, whom you longingly expect, will come to his temple. It is he who is the messenger of the covenant.

The poetic parallelisms highlight this verse as an important climax in this section:

the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to His temple—

the Messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight—see, He is coming,

3:1e
see, He is coming,”

- Listen/Be-aware^(plur), he is coming.”

see: See the note on 3:1a.

3:1f

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: The speech clause, says the LORD of Hosts (or “says the LORD”), occurs many times throughout the text. This emphasizes the fact that this is a direct message from the LORD. See note 1 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

the LORD of Hosts: This special title for the LORD occurs twenty-four times in Malachi. See the discussion of this term in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section in the Introduction.

Malachi 3:2

Section 2:17–3:5: The LORD revealed that he would come to judge and purify his people

2:17 is a transitional verse. In 2:10–16 Malachi and the LORD listed ways that the priests and people had been unfaithful. In 2:17, the focus becomes the LORD’s response to this unfaithfulness. So it seems best to consider 2:17 as the beginning of a new section, rather than as the end of the preceding section.

Notice also that this verse contains Malachi’s typical structure for beginning a new section:

1. a statement by the LORD,
2. a question challenging the LORD’s statement,
3. and then the development of the theme of the section.

See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

3:2

This verse contains two more rhetorical questions (in 3:2a and 3:2b). They are parallel to each other:

^{2a}But who can endure the day of His coming,

^{2b}And who can stand when He appears?

The LORD used these rhetorical questions to remind the people about something they all knew was true:

1. No one would be able to face the one whom he would send to judge them.

2. They would not be able to defend themselves before this judge.

Use the appropriate grammatical form in your language to show this in each of these verse parts.

3:2a

But who can endure the day of His coming?

- ¶ But will anyone endure his judgement on the day when he comes?
- ¶ When he the Lord comes to judge/punish people, no one will be able to survive that day.

But: The word But in the BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction *w-*. Here it indicates a contrast between 3:1 and 3:2. The actual coming of the LORD would not be like the people expected or desired. Express the contrast in a natural way in your language.

His coming: The words His in 3:2a and “He” in 3:2b refer to the Lord (Jesus Christ—the Messiah) spoken of in 3:1b. See also the note in 3:1d. Interpretation (1) is supported by Alden (1985), page 719, Clarke (1823), page 805, Lange (1876), pages 19–20, Redditt (1995), page 176, and by CEV, NASB and an NIV footnote. Interpretation (2) is supported by Merrill (1994) pages 431–433. Merrill, however, is inconsistent in that he capitalizes “He” in his translation, suggestion that the messenger is Jesus.

3:2b

And who can stand when He appears?

- Will anyone be able to stand before him when he reveals himself?
- No one will be able to stand/defend-himself.

And who can stand: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as can stand means almost the same as the verb which the BSB translates as “endure” in 3:2a. The idea is that no one will succeed in defending himself before the LORD when he comes to judge. In some languages it may be helpful to make that idea explicit. For example:

Who will be able to stand and face him when he appears? (NLT)

Who will be able to survive when he appears? (GNT)

3:2c

For He will be like a refiner’s fire,

- For he will be like the very hot fire that burns all the impurities in metal until it is pure.

a refiner’s fire: The word refiner refers to a person who purified metal by heating it until it was red hot. The very hot fire burned away all the impurities which were in the metal until only the pure metal remained.

3:2d

like a launderer’s soap.

- He will be like soap that washes clothes clean.

like a launderer’s soap: The word launderer’s refers to a person who washed/laundered clothes. He used a very strong soap to remove dirt and stains from cloth.

General Comments on 3:2c–d

The point of similarity in both metaphors is the same. In the first metaphor, the Lord will purify the people, just as a refiner’s fire refines/purifies metal and destroys the impurities in it. In the second metaphor, he will cleanse his people, just as the launderer’s strong soap cleans the dirt from dirty clothes.

GNT changes the order of 3:2c and 3:2d, possibly because 3:3 continues the illustration of refining metal.

^{2d}He will be like strong soap, ^{2c}like a fire that refines metal.

You should use the order that is most natural in your language.

Malachi 3:3

Section 2:17–3:5: The LORD revealed that he would come to judge and purify his people

2:17 is a transitional verse. In 2:10–16 Malachi and the LORD listed ways that the priests and people had been unfaithful. In 2:17, the focus becomes the LORD’s response to this unfaithfulness. So it seems best to consider 2:17 as the beginning of a new section, rather than as the end of the preceding section.

Notice also that this verse contains Malachi’s typical structure for beginning a new section:

1. a statement by the LORD,
2. a question challenging the LORD’s statement,
3. and then the development of the theme of the section.

See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

3:3a

And He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver;

- Yes, he will be like a metal-worker who burns all the impurities in silver until it is pure.

a refiner and purifier of silver: This phrase uses the same type of metaphor as 3:2c used. In this verse there is no difference in meaning between refiner and purifier.

3:3b

He will purify the sons of Levi

- He will remove all evil/sin/wickedness from the descendants of Levi.
- He will purify those who serve in the temple.

the sons of Levi: Since all priests were descendants of Levi, the sons of Levi included the priests. It also included other descendants of Levi who served in the temple in other ways.

If your readers do not know this, they will not understand the argument here. There are two ways to supply the information:

- Use the term “priests” in the text, as GNT has done:
- Use a footnote.

3:3c

and refine them like gold and silver.

- He will cleanse them until they are like pure gold and pure silver.

3:3d

Then they will present offerings to the LORD in righteousness.

- Then they will bring/offer to Yahweh the kind of sacrifices which they know are correct/right.

Then: The Hebrew conjunction *w-* is translated by the BSB as Then. Here it introduces the result of 3:3b–c. Other English versions translate it with “so that” or “till” (short for “until”). For example:

the LORD’s messenger will purify the priests, so that they will bring to the Lord the right kind of offerings. (GNT)

he will purify Levi’s sons and refine them like gold and silver, till they present right offerings to the Lord. (RSV)

Use what is natural in your language here.

they will present offerings to the LORD in righteousness: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as present offerings...in righteousness can have two possible interpretations here:

1. The phrase in righteousness qualifies offerings. This refers to offerings that are the sort of offering

that the LORD had told his people to bring, that is, unblemished offerings. For example:

Then they will offer the Lord a proper offering. (NET) (RSV, GNT, NET, NLT, CEV, GW)

1. The phrase in righteousness is adverbial, and it indicates the correct way to present offerings. This refers to the way the people were to present their offerings; that is, they were to present them in the proper way, as the LORD had told them to. For example:

and so they will be fit to bring offerings to the Lord. (REB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, KJV, NCV, NJPS, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Malachi 3:4

Section 2:17–3:5: The LORD revealed that he would come to judge and purify his people

2:17 is a transitional verse. In 2:10–16 Malachi and the LORD listed ways that the priests and people had been unfaithful. In 2:17, the focus becomes the LORD’s response to this unfaithfulness. So it seems best to consider 2:17 as the beginning of a new section, rather than as the end of the preceding section.

Notice also that this verse contains Malachi’s typical structure for beginning a new section:

1. a statement by the LORD,
2. a question challenging the LORD’s statement,
3. and then the development of the theme of the section.

See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

3:4a

Then the offerings of Judah and Jerusalem will please the LORD,

- Then the gifts/sacrifices that the people of the region of Judah and the city of Jerusalem bring to Yahweh will please him,

3:4b

as in days of old and years gone by.

- as they pleased him in the past at different times.
- as they did long ago.

as in days of old: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as as in days of old means “a long time ago.”

and years gone by: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as and years gone by means “in the past.”

These two phrases have almost the same meaning in Hebrew. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat similar meanings in two phrases, one after the other, as it is here. If that is true in your language, you may express the meaning only once. For example:

just as they did in the past. (CEV)

Malachi 3:5

Section 2:17–3:5: The LORD revealed that he would come to judge and purify his people

2:17 is a transitional verse. In 2:10–16 Malachi and the LORD listed ways that the priests and people had been unfaithful. In 2:17, the focus becomes the LORD’s response to this unfaithfulness. So it seems best to consider 2:17 as the beginning of a new section, rather than as the end of the preceding section.

Notice also that this verse contains Malachi’s typical structure for beginning a new section:

1. a statement by the LORD,
2. a question challenging the LORD’s statement,
3. and then the development of the theme of the section.

See note 6 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

3:5c against sorcerers

- against those who do witchcraft,

3:5d and adulterers

- against those who commit/do adultery,
- and to speak against those who are unfaithful to their husbands or wives

3:5h and deny justice to the foreigner

- and who push aside strangers/foreigners who are living in their villages.

3:5

Notice that GNT begins this verse with the phrase:

The Lord Almighty says. (GNT)

In the Hebrew text, these words are at the end of 3:5 (as in the BSB). GNT moved these words to the beginning of 3:5 to make it clear that it was the LORD who

was speaking here, not Malachi. Consider whether it may be necessary to do the same in your language.

3:5a

“Then I will draw near to you for judgment.

- ¶ “I will come to you^(plur) in order to judge you^(plur).
- ¶ Yahweh says, “I will come near to judge you^(plur).

Then: The Hebrew conjunction *w-* is translated by the BSB as Then. Here it introduces a new paragraph. The events which the LORD described in this paragraph would happen before the events of the preceding paragraph or at the same time. You will need to translate the connection in an appropriate way to avoid confusion in your language. English versions translate it with expressions like “then,” “at that time” or “so.” Some versions omit it. Use what would be natural in your language in this context.

I will draw near to you for judgment: That is, I will come to you, in order to judge you. This judgment would be an answer to the accusation of the people in 2:17, “Where is the God of justice?”

3:5b

And I will be a swift witness

- I will be quick to speak

And I will be a swift witness: Other ways to express this are:

I will quickly condemn. (CEV)

I will act as a relentless accuser. (NJPS)

Do not use a term which would imply that the LORD was simply a witness, whose testimony would be compared with that of others. We must not imagine that the scene here is that of a courtroom, for then Yahweh would seem, in the modern conception, to be in the role of witness, not of judge. Rather, the scene is that of a disobedient servant hauled before the Great King (Mal. 1:14) and accused by the King himself of covenant breaking. The whole interior dynamic of the book of Malachi is one of a *rîb*, that is, a juridical proceeding against covenant breakers. The Great King (the Hittite emperors were called that) is both accuser and judge. Witnesses are only incidental to the proceeding (Pohlig, personal communication).

3:5e

and perjurers,

- against those who tell lies in the court,
- and to speak against those who tell lies when they have sworn/promised to tell the truth,

perjurers: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as perjurers means to swear that a false statement is really true.

**3:5f
against oppressors of the widowed and fatherless,**

- and to speak against those who cheat/take-advantage-of widows and orphans,

**3:5g
and against those who defraud laborers of their wages**

- against any person who refuses to give those who work for him the money he owes them,
- and to speak against those who do not give their workers the money they deserve,

**3:5f-g
defraud:** The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as defraud in 3:5g applies to the widow and orphan in 3:5f also. The word means “to wrong, cheat, oppress.”

**3:5i
but do not fear Me,”**

- Indeed I will speak against all those people who do not fear/respect me.”

In 3:5c-h the LORD gave a list of the categories of people whom he will judge. 3:5i is not simply a continuation of this list; it applies to each of the groups of people listed in 3:5c-h.

do not fear Me: The Hebrew word *mora'* which the BSB translates as fear can also mean “reverence” or “awe.” It is translated in many English versions as “respect.”

**3:5j
says the LORD of Hosts.**

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaoth.
- Yahweh Sabaoth has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaoth says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: This speech clause occurs many times throughout the text. The repetition emphasizes the fact that this is a direct message from the LORD. See the note on 3:1f. See also note 1 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

Notice that in the BSB this clause occurs after the speech. This is good English style. You should place it wherever is natural in your language.

the LORD of Hosts: This special title for the LORD occurs twenty-four times in Malachi. See the note on 3:1f. See also the discussion of this term in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section of the Introduction.

General Comment on 3:5b-j

As stated above, 3:5i applies to each of the groups of people listed in 3:5c-h. It is not simply another category of people whom the LORD will judge. In some languages it will be clearer if the verse is re-ordered. The NJPS re-orders this verse to show this clearly:

^{5b}and I will act as a relentless accuser ⁵ⁱagainst those who have no fear of Me: ^{5c}Who practice sorcery, ^{5d}who commit adultery, ^{5e}who swear falsely, ^{5g}who cheat laborers of their hire, ^{5f}and who subvert [the cause of] the widow, orphan, ^{5h}and stranger, ⁵ⁱsaid the Lord of Hosts. (NJPS)

Malachi 3:6

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:6

As this is a new section, it may be helpful in some languages to begin this verse with a speech clause like, “The LORD says.” This will make it clear that the LORD was still speaking, the same as he was doing at the end of the previous section.

3:6a

“Because I, the LORD, do not change,

- ¶ “I, Yahweh, I do not change.
- ¶ “Since I, Yahweh, do not change what I have promised.

Because: The Hebrew word *ki* which the BSB translates as Because introduces the reason. Another possible way to interpret *kî* here is as an “assertive intensifier,” that is, it means something like “truly, indeed.” This verse is then asserting or insisting on a truth which may be contrary to the expectation of the hearers. See Verhoef (1987). for the following statement in 3:6b. A third interpretation is suggested by Glazier-McDonald (1987⁽¹⁾), taking *kî* as causal, introducing the reason why Yahweh has not changed: ‘because I am Yahweh, I have not changed.’ The statement ‘because I am Yahweh I have not changed’ then serves as the

basis for the Yahweh's appeal to the people to repent and return to him (3:6–12). Carl Follingstad (personal communication) has this to say in support of the first interpretation given in the Notes: "In many cases, *kî* is used to metarepresent a correcting thought relative to some assumed incorrect one held by the hearer. This is called assertive focus in Functional Grammar. In the English example, 'he went' versus 'he DID go,' the 'did' [termed 'do periphrasis'] with focus intonation in the second sentence marks assertive focus—it means that the proposition 'he went' is not only stated, but positively asserted relative to some hesitant or contrary presupposition, whether implied or explicitly stated previously by the speaker himself in the context...it is primarily the focus intonation on NOT that is the equivalent of *kî* in English....*kî* in Mal 3:6 is probably metarepresenting (or asserting) a correcting proposition relative to one which the speaker assumes the hearer/reader has at that point. Yahweh (through the prophet representing Yahweh) assumes the hearer/reader has overlooked, is hesitant about, or disbelieves the proposition 'I the Lord do not change (contrary to your presupposition that I may change, or lack of appreciation or belief that I still judge the unjust, etc).'" For further discussion on the function of *kî* in Hebrew discourse, see Follingstad (2001). Some ways to express the connection in English are:

Since, I, the Lord, do not go back on my promises, you, sons of Jacob, have not perished. (NET)

I am the Lord, and I do not change. That is why you descendants of Jacob are not already completely destroyed. (NLT)

I am the Lord, and I do not change. And so you, the descendants of Jacob, are not yet completely lost. (GNT)

I, the LORD, do not change: The people of Israel had not kept the LORD's covenant. And in 2:17–3:5, the LORD warned them that he would judge them. So a reader might expect that the LORD would abandon the people of Israel and destroy them completely. But what the LORD said here was contrary to that expectation. He was reminding the people that he never changes, and therefore, in spite of all their unfaithfulness, he would still keep his covenant with them. So this section, 3:6–18, called the people of Israel to repent and begin to follow him again.

3:6b

you descendants of Jacob have not been destroyed.

- That is why you^(plur), descendants of Jacob, have not been destroyed.
- I have not destroyed you^(plur) descendants of Jacob, as you^(plur) deserve.

you descendants of Jacob: This refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to your readers to use a footnote to explain that the expression descendants of Jacob here refers to the people of Israel.

Jacob: The name Jacob, rather than "Israel," is often used in passages which focus on the weakness of the people of Israel. The name Jacob reminds people of a human being with weaknesses and frailty. "Israel" was the name God gave Jacob when he gave him a special position as the ancestor of the people of Israel.

have not been destroyed: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as have not been destroyed has the basic meaning of "bring to an end." Scholars understand it in different ways in this verse:

1. It means "have not been destroyed" or "have not ceased to exist." In this context it implies that God had not destroyed the people of Israel because he never changes. This implies that he will remain faithful to the covenant he made with them. For example:

So you, O descendants of Jacob, are not destroyed. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, NLT, NCV, GW, KJV, NASB, NET)

1. It means "have not ceased to be sons (descendants) of Jacob." This interpretation follows the LXX. It probably involves an implied reference to the meaning of the name "Jacob," that is, "deceiver." In this context it implies that they have not ceased to be deceivers like their ancestor Jacob. This meaning relates closely to the idea of the following verse. For example:

and you have not ceased to be children of Jacob. (REB) (NJB, REB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

Malachi 3:7

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the "Statement, Question, Response" pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The "Statement-Question" part occurs twice before a longer "Response" is given.

(Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:7a

Yet from the days of your fathers,

- From long ago at the time of your^(plur) ancestors until now,

Yet from the days of your fathers: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as from the days of your fathers means “ever since the time of your ancestors and continuing to the present time.” It indicates here that their ancestors also in each generation had been disobeying the LORD’s commands.

your fathers: That is, “your ancestors.”

3:7b

you have turned away from My statutes

- in each generation you^(plur) have rejected my commandments/laws

you have turned away from My statutes: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as turned away is the same one which was used in 2:8a. It is used as an idiom here. It means “to reject” the statutes of the LORD.

you: In this context, the LORD referred to the people of Israel in each generation who did not obey him. In some languages it may not be natural to address past generations in the same group with the living. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to use a comparison to express the idea. For example:

You, like your ancestors before you, have turned away from my laws. (GNT)

statutes: Hebrew has a number of different words which are used to refer to laws and commandments. Sometimes it is important to distinguish between them, but in this verse, the LORD referred to all the laws which he gave to Moses. You can use your usual term for “law” or “commandments.”

3:7c

and have not kept them.

- and have not obeyed them.

and have not kept them: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as have not kept indicates that they did not obey those laws.

3:7d

Return to Me, and I will return to you,”

- Turn back^(plur) and commit yourselves^(plur) to obey me again, and I will also turn back to bless you^(plur) again.”
- Repent^(plur) and be faithful to me again, and then I also will be faithful to bless you^(plur) again.”

Return to Me, and I will return to you: The same Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as Return is used in both parts of 3:7d. Like the verb in 3:7b, it is used as an idiom. It implies that the relationship between the people and the LORD has been damaged and needs to be repaired. To Return would mean they must do what was necessary to again have a loving relationship with the LORD (that is, to be reconciled).

For the people and the LORD to be reconciled, the word Return has a slightly different meaning in the two contexts. Firstly, the people must repent of their sins and once more obey the LORD’s law. Then the LORD would forgive them and again bless them.

In some languages it may not be possible to use the same verb for the actions of both the people and the LORD. If that is true in your language, you should use the appropriate specific verbs. For example:

Repent and be faithful to me again, and I will be faithful also to bless you.

3:7e

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f. See also note 1 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” section of the Introduction.

Notice that in the BSB this clause occurs after the speech. This is good English style. You should place it wherever is natural in your language.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f. See also the discussion of this term in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section of the Introduction.

3:7f

“But you ask,

- “But you^(plur) ask,

3:7g**'How can we return?'**

- 'In what way/ways should we^(excl) turn back to you^(sing)?'
- 'What should we^(excl) repent of and stop doing?'

How can we return?: This question probably implies that the people did not recognize the ways in which they had stopped obeying the LORD. They were asking him in what way they should return to him; in other words, what things they should repent of and stop doing. For example:

But you ask, "What must we do to turn back to you?" (GNT)

Malachi 3:8

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them
Notice that this section also starts with the "Statement, Question, Response" pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The "Statement-Question" part occurs twice before a longer "Response" is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The "Statement-Question-Response" pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:8b**Yet you are robbing Me!**

- But you^(plur) are cheating me.
- Yet you^(plur) are stealing from me.

3:8c**But you ask,**

- But you^(plur) ask again,

3:8d**'How do we rob You?'**

- 'In what way are we^(excl) cheating you?^(sing)'
- 'What are we^(excl) stealing from you?^(sing)'

3:8

The people have just asked "How can we return?" In 3:8 and the following verses, the LORD begins to answer that question.

3:8a**Will a man rob God?**

- Do you^(plur) not realise that it is sinful for a person to cheat God?

- I tell you,^(plur) it is wrong for a human being to steal from God.

Will a man rob God?: This is a rhetorical question. The question implies horror that such a thing could happen and yet it was happening. If you do not use rhetorical questions in this way in your language, you could use a statement. Here is one example:

It is wrong for a human being to rob God.NET has a note: "The LXX presupposes *bq*, "deceive," a metathesis of *bq*, "rob," in all four uses of the verb here. The intent probably is to soften the impact of robbing God, but the language of the passage is intentionally bold and there is no reason to go against the reading of the MT." Some Bible versions (NLT, GW, NJB) follow that reading. It also has the attraction that this form of the verb would, in Hebrew, be a pun with the name for Jacob. However the MT (Hebrew text) makes good sense too, and there do not seem to be sufficient grounds for not following the Hebrew text.

a man: This refers to human beings, not males only.

3:8e**In tithes and offerings.**

- You^(plur) cheat me by not bringing me your^(plur) tithes and offerings.
- You^(plur) steal from me the tithes and offerings that you^(plur) ought to bring to my temple.

tithes: This refers to the tenth part of all the crops which the people of Israel produced on their farms. According to the laws which the LORD gave to Moses, each person had to give one tenth back to the LORD. This was to supply food for the priests who did not have farms of their own because they were working in the temple. See Leviticus 27:30 and Numbers 18:21–29.

offerings: In this context the Hebrew word *t̄aruma* which the BSB translates as offerings refers to the cereal and/or animal offerings, which also provided food for the priests.Redditt (1995), page 179.

Malachi 3:9

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them
Notice that this section also starts with the "Statement, Question, Response" pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The "Statement-Question" part occurs twice before a longer "Response" is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The "Statement-Question-Response" pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

tion-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:9a

You are cursed with a curse,

- You^(plur) are greatly cursed
- I am already punishing you^(plur)

You are cursed with a curse: In Hebrew this is a strong statement which would be better translated: “you are greatly cursed” or “you are truly under a curse” in English.

If people are cursed, they suffer under the LORD’s punishment, instead of enjoying his favor. It is the opposite of being blessed. See the note on 1:14a.

In some languages the word for “curse” might convey a wrong meaning if you used it here. If that is true in your language, it may be more accurate if you use the idea that the LORD would judge or punish them. For example:

You are bound for judgement... (NET)

In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea with an intransitive verb or with an active expression. For example:

You are suffering under a curse... (NJPS)

You are suffering because I have cursed you...

The LORD was not specific in this verse about the way that he would curse or punish the people. However 3:10-12 implies that their crops were destroyed.

3:9b

yet you—the whole nation—are still robbing Me.

- because you^(plur) are all cheating me.
- because all of you^(plur), the whole nation of Israel, are stealing from me.

you—the whole nation: Scholars differ about whom this expression identifies. There are two options:

1. It identifies those who are robbing God. For example:

^{9a}A curse is on all of you ^{9b}because the whole nation is cheating me. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NJB, NLT, KJV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS)

1. It identifies those who are under a curse. For example:

You are under a curse—the whole nation of you—because you are robbing me. (NIV) (NIV, REB, CEV)

Both of these options are true. The whole nation has been robbing God, and the whole nation is under a curse because of that. You should express this idea in the most natural way in your language.

If you must make one of these options explicit, it is recommended that you follow option (1).

Malachi 3:10

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:10a

Bring the full tithe into the storehouse,

- Bring^(plur) the tithes of all that you^(plur) earn and put/place^(plur) them in the store rooms in my temple,

Bring the full tithe: That is, “bring everything you owe God—the tenth part (tithe) of all that you produce or earn.” See the note on “tithes” in 3:8e.

into the storehouse: That is, into the storerooms in the temple. There was a special place in the temple where the tithes were brought and stored. See Nehemiah 13:12.

3:10b

so that there may be food in My house.

- so that there may be plenty of food there.

so that there may be food in My house: This phrase gives the reason for 3:10a. The food probably refers to the tithes which the people gave from their crops. They were stored in rooms in the temple and used as food by the priests.

3:10c

Test Me in this,”

- By doing this, test^(plur) me,”

Test Me in this: That is, learn whether I have spoken the truth. The complete sense of this will be understood better from 3:10e.

3:10d

says the LORD of Hosts.

- these are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- this is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f. In Hebrew this speech clause occurs in the middle of a sentence and thought. In Hebrew this emphasizes that the LORD was the one who was speaking. In some languages it may not be natural to use the speech clause in this position in the sentence. If that is true in your language, it may be best to place the clause at the beginning or end of the sentence.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

3:10e

“See if I will not open the windows of heaven and pour out for you blessing without measure.

- “then you^(plur) will see that I will indeed cause plentiful blessings to come to you^(plur), as though I had opened heaven’s windows and poured them out like heavy rain.
- “If you do this, I will certainly bless you^(plur) abundantly, with more than enough for your^(plur) every need.

open the windows of heaven and pour out for you blessing without measure: This is the fulfilment of 3:10c. If the people of Israel give the LORD what they owe him (their tithes), he will bless them.

The phrase open the windows of heaven is a figure of speech. It implies falling rain. People can imagine that someone opened a window high above and poured water onto the ground below. Rain is closely associated with blessing in the Old Testament (Deuteronomy 11:13–14). Here the figure of speech is that the LORD would send blessings from heaven abundantly like rain would pour from the sky. In other words, it is a promise that the LORD would bless the people abundantly.

In some languages this figure of speech may not be clearly understood. If that is true in your language, there are other options for translation:

- Translate the meaning directly, and use the figure of speech as a simile. For example:

I will bless you abundantly. It will be as though I had opened windows in heaven and poured down blessings.

I will bless you with blessings as abundant as heavy rain falling from heaven.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech, but use another way to emphasize the abundance of the LORD’s blessing. For example:

I will bless you so greatly that the blessing cannot be measured.

Use an option which is natural and clear in your language.

Malachi 3:11

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:11a

I will rebuke the devourer for you,

- For you^(plur) I will not allow the locusts and other destructive insects
- For your^(plur) sake I will prevent damaging insects from coming

rebuke the devourer: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as rebuke the devourer is used as a figure of speech in this context. It indicates that the LORD would prevent insects from eating the crops.

the devourer: This refers primarily to locusts which come in large numbers and eat everything that grows, so that there are no crops left to harvest. It can refer also to any other kind of destructive insect that destroys plants.

3:11b

so that it will not destroy the fruits of your land,

- to destroy what you^(plur) grow on your^(plur) land,
- so that they will not eat your^(plur) crops,

the fruits of your land: That is, the crops on your farm, the food that grows in your garden.

3:11c
and the vine in your field will not fail to produce fruit,”

- and your^(plur) vines will not fail to produce much fruit.”
- and your^(plur) grape vines will bear much fruit.”

the vine in your field: Vines produced one of the most important crops for the people of Israel, that is, grapes. Wine was made from the juice of this fruit.

will not fail to produce fruit: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as fail to produce means here “fail to bear fruit” or “miscarry.” It may refer to fruit dropping off the vine before it is ripe, while it is still not ready to eat.

3:11d
says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

Malachi 3:12

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:12a
“Then all the nations will call you blessed,

- “Then all people will recognise that Yahweh has blessed you^(plur),
- “The people of all the other nations will see these things, and they will say, ‘Yahweh has done good things for you^(plur),’

Then: The Hebrew conjunction w- which the BSB translates here as Then probably expresses the result of

3:11. Some ways to say this in English are: “Because of this” or “Therefore.”

all the nations will call you blessed: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as call...blessed comes from a different verb than the word which was translated as “blessing” in 3:10. Here the verb means “to call/consider (someone) happy or blessed.”

In this verse the main point is that other nations would recognize that the people of Israel were fortunate because the LORD had blessed them. For example:

Then all nations will count you happy. (NRSV)

Since the LORD was the one who would have made the people happy and fortunate, it may be helpful in some languages to make this explicit. For example:

Everyone of every nation will talk about how I have blessed you... (CEV)

3:12b
for you will be a land of delight,”

- because there will be much joy in your^(plur) land.”
- because there will be many things to make you^(plur) happy in your^(plur) land.”

a land of delight: That is, a place where there are many good things that make people happy.

3:12c
says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

Malachi 3:13

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:13a

“Your words against Me have been harsh,”

- ¶ “You^(plur) have spoken many harsh words against me.”
- ¶ “You^(plur) have been very critical of me.”
- ¶ “You^(plur) have spoken of me harshly.”

Your words against Me have been harsh: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as have been harsh has the basic meaning of “to be strong.” Glazier-McDonald (1987) argues that the meaning here is ‘your words are too much for me’; this rendering is based on Akkadian parallels. She points out that this interpretation creates a parallel with Malachi 2:17: there the people’s words have wearied Yahweh, while here they have gotten worse, becoming intolerable for him. The Hebrew perfect tense having present effect, so some translators use the present tense in translation: ‘your words are too much for me,’ or at least, ‘your words are hard against me.’ In this verse it applies to Your words, and refers to words that are “terrible/severe.” English versions express this idea in different ways. For example:

You have said harsh things against me. (NIV)

You have said terrible things about me. (GNT)

You have criticised me sharply. (NET)

Express this meaning in a natural way in your language.

3:13b

says the LORD.

- These are the words of Yahweh.
- Yahweh has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh says to you^(plur).

says the LORD: See the note on 1:2b.

3:13c

“Yet you ask,

- “But you^(plur) ask,

3:13d

‘What have we spoken against You?’

- ‘What evil/bad things have we^(excl) spoken against you?^(sing)’
- ‘In what way have we^(excl) spoken against you?^(sing)’

Malachi 3:14

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:14a

You have said,

- You^(plur) have said,

3:14b

‘It is futile to serve God.

- ‘Serving God is futile.
- ‘It is useless to worship and serve God.

It is futile to serve God: That is, it is pointless/useless to serve God. This is a return to the topic which had caused God to be upset with the people (see 2:17).

to serve God: Here to serve means “to worship, to behave in a proper way towards God.”

3:14c

What have we gained by keeping His requirements

- What benefit is it to us^(excl) if we^(excl) obey his commands,
- You^(plur) also say, ‘What difference does it make if we^(excl) obey him?’

keeping His requirements: That is, obeying his commandments.

3:14d

and walking mournfully before the LORD of Hosts?

- and if we^(excl) humbly mourn because of our^(excl) sins in the presence of Yahweh Sabaot?
- What difference does it make if we^(excl) humble ourselves^(excl) before Yahweh Sabaot and weep because we^(excl) have sinned?

walking mournfully: That is, the people were “behaving as those who are truly sorry for the sins they have committed.” This implied that they had truly repented and were obeying the LORD once more. It contrasts with 3:15a, which mentions “the arrogant” people.

General Comment on 3:14c–d

In 3:14c–d the people asked a rhetorical question. The question emphasizes the idea in 3:14b and adds further details. If you would not use a question in that way in your language, it may be better to use a statement. For example:

^{14a}You have said, ^{14b}“It is useless to serve God. ^{14c}It did no good to obey his laws ^{14d}and to show the Lord All-Powerful that we were sorry for what we did.” (NCV)

Malachi 3:15

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:15a

So now we call the arrogant blessed.

- Therefore we^(excl) conclude that it is the proud/arrogant people who prosper/succeed.
- From now on we^(excl) consider that it is the proud people whom God blesses.

So now: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as So now introduces a conclusion. One way to make this connection clearer would be to translate something like this: “Therefore we have concluded that...”

we call the arrogant blessed: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as call...blessed is the same one used in 3:12a. See the note on 3:12a. You may be able to translate it here also in a similar way. For example:

As we see it, proud people are the ones who are happy. (GNT)

This statement implied that God was acting unfairly. In the people’s opinion, he was actually blessing arrogant people even more than he blessed the people who were humbly repentant (3:14).

we call: That is, we think/count/consider.

3:15b

Not only do evildoers prosper,

- Not only do those who do evil have success,

3:15b–c

Not only...even: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as Not only...even is gam...gam in Hebrew. The first gam makes the first statement emphatic. The second gam makes the following statement even more emphatic than the first one. Some English versions simply join the two statements with “and” or with a combination like “not only...but” (RSV). Others use emphatic words like “indeed,” “even,” or “in fact.” For example:

Not only are evildoers encouraged, they even test God and get away with it. (GW)

Certainly the evildoers prosper, and even those who challenge God escape. (NIV)

Use an option which is natural in your language.

3:15c

they even test God and escape.”

- but when they test God, they even escape punishment.”
- but when they act wickedly to test God, he does not even punish them.”

they even test God: That means that these people acted wickedly to test God. The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as test is the same word that was translated “test” in 3:10c. There God asked them to test whether he would bless them or not. Here they tested God’s patience, to see if he would punish them or not.

escape: That is, escape punishment. No matter how badly they behaved, God did not seem to punish them as they deserved.

Malachi 3:16

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:16a

At that time those who feared the LORD spoke with one another,

- ¶ Then those people who feared/revered Yahweh spoke to one another.

At that time: In this context, the Hebrew word *ʾaz* which the BSB translates as *At that time* most probably indicates that this verse contrasts with the previous paragraph. In contrast to the people referred to in 3:14–15, this verse refers to people who feared the LORD.

those who feared the LORD: This refers to the people who were faithful to the LORD and respected him. See the note on 1:6c–d.

Scholars differ about exactly who these people were:

1. They were people who accepted Malachi's warnings and then spoke respectfully about the LORD.
2. They were people who already respected the LORD before Malachi's warning. The verse refers to their reaction when other people accused the LORD.

The Hebrew text allow either interpretation, and English versions are also ambiguous. If possible, you should try to translate so that either view could be understood. If that is not possible in your language, it is recommended that you follow option (1). TOB (Traduction Œcuménique de la Bible), following the Septuagint, translates *ʾaz* as *ainsi*, 'thus,' leading to quite a different interpretation: the complaints recorded in verses 14–15 are understood as coming from God's faithful people. They are struggling to remain faithful, but are losing ground. In spite of their struggles, God still hears them anyway.

spoke with one another: We do not know what these people said to each other. It must have been something which pleased the LORD because he responded favorably to their words (3:16b).

3:16b

and the LORD listened and heard them.

- Yahweh heard their words, and considered/paid-attention-to what they said.
- Yahweh listened carefully to what they said.

This verse part begins with the Hebrew conjunction *w*. It introduces the LORD's response to those who feared him. Most English versions translate it as "and." Use what is natural in your language in this context to introduce the LORD's response.

listened and heard them: The Hebrew words which the BSB translates as *listened and heard* mean almost the same thing in this context. The author used both verbs here to emphasize the action, that is, to mean something like "listened very carefully." There are at least two possibilities for translation:

- Use two similar verbs. For example:

the Lord paid attention and listened. (GW)

- Use one verb, and emphasize it in some way.

the LORD listened very carefully.

Use an option which will be natural in your language for this context.

3:16c

So a scroll of remembrance was written before Him regarding those who feared the LORD

- Therefore Yahweh/he caused a book to be written in his presence with records of those people who feared/revered him

a scroll of remembrance was written before Him regarding those who feared the LORD: This indicates

that a record was written in a book about the people who feared the LORD. The record probably mentioned their names and also may have included their words and deeds which showed their faithfulness to him. Someone wrote this record in the LORD's presence. Malachi does not tell us who this person was. For example:

In his presence, there was written down in a book a record of those who feared the Lord and respected him. (GNT)

scroll: At the time when Malachi prophesied, books as we know them today did not exist. People wrote on stone tablets, scrolls of leather or other materials. You should choose a general term here which represents a well known substance on which people would keep written records.

regarding those who feared the LORD: The Hebrew word *l* which the BSB translates as *regarding* at this point in the verse can have many meanings. Here the context indicates that the book was written "for the benefit of" those who feared the LORD. The LORD would remember them (and what they had said or done).

those who feared the LORD: See the note on 3:16a.

3:16d and honored His name.

- and thought about him with awe/reverence.

and honored His name: That is, they honored his name, they thought about him with reverence. For example:

those who feared the Lord and respected him.
(GNT)

His name: In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “the LORD’s name” or His name refers to God himself or his authority. It was also used in this way in 1:6. See the note on 1:6f. GNT simply uses “him” instead of His name.

General Comment on 3:16c–d

The Hebrew expressions which the BSB translates as “feared the LORD” in 3:16c and “honored His name” in 3:16d mean almost the same thing. In some languages it may be more natural to express this idea in another way. Some possibilities are:

- Express the idea only once. For example:

those who revered the LORD.

those who esteemed the LORD in their thoughts.

- Change the order of the expressions. For example:

those who meditated about the LORD and revered him.

- Use a compound verb, adverb or other element. For example:

those who honored the LORD with reverence and esteem.

Use an option which is natural in your language.

Malachi 3:17

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them

Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

tion-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:17a “They will be Mine,”

- “I will make these people who revere me my very own,”

They will be Mine: This indicates that the people who feared the LORD would belong to him in a special sense as his people. This may be difficult to express in some languages. It may seem obvious that everyone and everything already belongs to the LORD. This is true in the sense that he has control over them. However the meaning in this verse is that the LORD will give these people a special relationship with himself.

They: This refers to the people who feared the LORD and who have just been mentioned in 3:16.

3:17b says the LORD of Hosts,

- Yahweh Sabaot declares,
- Yahweh Sabaot says,

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

3:17c “on the day when I prepare My treasured possession.

- “on that day when I will act to judge people. I will cause them to be like a special treasure to me.

on the day when I prepare My treasured possession: There are different interpretations of this verse part. The two major views are:

1. The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as prepare has a general meaning. What the LORD will do on the day is not mentioned specifically here. For example:

On the day when I act, they will be my own special treasure. (NLT) (RSV, NJB, GNT, NLT, NJPS, REB)

1. The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as prepare relates specifically to the expression which the BSB translates as My treasured possession. For example:

in the day when I make up my treasured possession. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, NASB, KJV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Hebrew word translated prepare is a general word. However, in this context it refers to the day when the LORD will act as judge to punish or reward people.

My treasured possession: This expression reflects the words of the covenant which the LORD made with the people of Israel at Sinai. In that covenant he chose them to be his own people, to belong to him (Exodus 19:5). The expression used here (My treasured possession) implies that they were special to him and that he would especially value them.

In some languages, it may not be natural to speak of people as a possession in this way. Some other possibilities for translation are:

- Use a simile. For example:

They will be like a treasure to me.

They will be as precious to me as a king's most treasured possession.

- Omit the reference to a possession.

they will be my very own. (GNT)

they will be my own special treasure. (NLT)

You people are precious to me. (CEV)

Use an option which will be natural in your language.

General Comment on 3:17a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to re-order some of the information in 3:17a–c. For example:

^{17b}Yahweh Sabaot says, ^{17c}“On that day when I will come and judge people, I will take these people who respected me to belong to me in a special way ^{17a}and they will be my very own.”

^{17b}The Lord All-Powerful says, ^{17a}“They belong to me; ^{17c}on that day they will be my very own.” (NCV)

3:17d

And I will spare them as a man spares his own son who serves him.

- In compassion I will spare them from judgement, just as a father shows compassion/mercy to his child who obeys him.
- As a father shows mercy to his obedient child and does not punish him severely, I will also show mercy to them.

I will spare them: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as spare indicates that the LORD would have mercy on these people and spare them from judgement. That is, he would not punish them. Most English versions use the word spare (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, NLT, REB, KJV, NASB NJB GW), but some versions use the idea of “mercy,” “compassion,” or “protection.” (GNT, CEV, NCV, NJPS) Here are examples of translation possibilities:

I will spare them, just as in compassion a man spares his son who serves him. (NIV)

As a parent shows mercy to his child who serves him, I will show mercy to my people. (NCV)

who serves him: This refers to a person who loyally obeys the LORD and submits to his will. Use a natural expression in your language for obeying or submitting to someone in authority. This same expression is also used in 3:18b.

Malachi 3:18

Section 3:6–18: If the people again start to give the LORD what they owe him, he will again bless them Notice that this section also starts with the “Statement, Question, Response” pattern. However this time the sequence is expanded. The “Statement-Question” part occurs twice before a longer “Response” is given. (Another difference is that the second statement begins with a short question.) The “Statement-Question-Response” pattern marks the beginning of a new section.

3:6 is a transitional verse, as 2:17 was. Again, it is recommended that you take it as the first verse of this new section.

3:18a

So you will again distinguish between the righteous and the wicked,

- Then you^(plur) will again realise that I do treat the righteous people and the wicked people in different ways,
- At that time, you^(plur) shall see/understand that those people who do/act right and those who do evil are different to me.

So: The word So in the BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction *w-*. In this context the text probably implies that 3:18 is the result of God's actions in 3:17. When the LORD spares the people who serve him, people will again understand that there is a difference in the way he treats righteous people and wicked people. This will be an answer to their accusations in 3:14–15.

In some languages it may be helpful to use a time phrase like “When that happens.” Use what is natural in your language for this context.

you will again distinguish between the righteous and the wicked: That is, you will be able to understand the difference between righteous people and wicked people in the way I treat them. GNT makes this explicit:

my people will see the difference between what happens to the righteous and to the wicked. (GNT)

again: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as again used in this context implies that in the past they had realized the difference between the way the LORD treated righteous people and the way he treated wicked people. Now they would understand that difference again.

the righteous: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as the righteous means “(those who) conform to a standard.” In this context, it refers to people who behave according to the LORD's standards and do what he considers to be right.

the wicked: This refers to people who do evil. It is the opposite of “the righteous.”

3:18b

between those who serve God and those who do not.”

- you^(plur) will know that those who serve/obey God are treated differently from those who do not.”
- Those who serve/obey God/me are the ones whom I will spare, and those who do not obey me are the ones whom I will judge/punish.”

those who serve God: This verb also occurred in 3:17. Try to translate it in the same way here. See the note on 3:17d.

God: In this verse God is still speaking. However he uses his title to speak about himself. In some languages it may be necessary to add a pronoun like “me” here to make this explicit. For example:

...one who serves me, God.

General Comment on 3:18a–b

The two parts of this verse (3:18a and 3:18b) mean almost the same thing. “those who serve God” (3:18b) is another way to refer to “the righteous” person (3:18a). “those who do not” serve God is another way to refer to “the wicked” person. Alden (1985), page 723; Baldwin (1972), page 249.

In some languages it may be helpful to combine these expressions. For example:

...between those who obey me by doing right and those who reject me by doing wrong. (CEV)

Malachi 4:1

Section 4:1–6: One day the LORD will come and judge all people

In the Hebrew text these verses are still part of chapter 3 and are numbered 3:19–24. Some English translations follow that Hebrew verse numbering, but in this book, the notes follow the more common English convention. It is recommended that you follow the numbering system of the versions used most in your area.

4:1

Notice that 4:1 uses the same image of refining that was used in 3:1–3.

The LORD is still speaking in 4:1, but the Hebrew text does not make this explicit until 4:1d. In some languages it may be helpful to change this order and begin the verse with this speech clause. For example:

The Lord Almighty says, “The day is coming...” (GNT)

4:1a

“For behold, the day is coming, burning like a furnace,

- ¶ “Listen^(plur). The day is coming soon, a day that will be like a burning fire in an oven.
- ¶ “Beware^(plur). The day when I will judge people is certainly coming. The punishment I pronounce on that day will be like a huge fire in a furnace.

For: The Hebrew word *ki* which the BSB translates as For introduces a clause which further explains the time when the event in 3:18 would happen. The clause uses figures of speech to explain how people would know the difference between righteous people and wicked ones. Try to find a natural way to express this connection in your translation. In some languages the

connection may be implied and may not require a connector in the text.

behold: The Hebrew word *hinneh* which the BSB translates as *behold* was also used in 2:3a and 3:1a. In the same way as it was used in those verses, it is used here to draw attention to what follows. In this context it also announces something which was certain to happen soon because it was the LORD who would cause it to happen.

the day is coming: This refers to the day/time when the LORD will come to judge everyone. In other parts of the Bible, this time is called “the day of the LORD.” In this context it may refer to a time period longer than a 24-hour day.

In this verse *day* is also used as a figure of speech. It refers to what will happen on that day, that is, the way the LORD will judge/punish people.

burning like a furnace: This verse uses a simile to compare the day when the LORD will judge people to a furnace or large oven where people/things could be burned up. On that day the LORD will punish people severely and destroy them like the fire in a furnace burns things and destroys them.

In some languages it may not be natural to compare a day with a furnace. It may be necessary to make the meaning explicit. For example:

The day when I judge people will certainly come.
The judgements of that day will be like fire in an oven...

4:1b

when all the arrogant and every evildoer will be stubble;

- It will destroy all the people who are proud, and all the people who do evil. They will be like dry grass/straw that immediately burns in a fire.
- I will destroy all the people who are proud and all the people who do evil.

all the arrogant and every evildoer will be stubble: There is a metaphor here. In 4:1a the day of judgement was compared to a furnace which would burn people/things up. In this part of the verse those who are proud and do evil are compared to stubble.

the arrogant: This is the same word which was used in 3:15a. You should translate it in a similar way here.

evildoer: The Hebrew word used here is very similar in meaning to the one which the BSB translates as “wicked” in 3:18a. It refers to people who do what is

evil, that is, what the LORD considers to be wrong. If possible you should use the same term here as you did in 3:18.

stubble: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as *stubble* refers to the straw which remains after the wheat grains have been removed during the harvest. It burns easily because it is very dry.

General Comment on 4:1b

In some languages it may not be clear how the arrogant and evil people are like stubble. The idea is probably that they will be destroyed very easily and quickly on the day of judgement. It may sometimes be necessary to make the meaning explicit in your translation. For example:

All the people who are arrogant and who do evil
will be destroyed as quickly as stubble burns up.

4:1c

the day is coming when I will set them ablaze,”

- On that day they will be burnt/destroyed completely,”

the day is coming when I will set them ablaze: This sentence continues to use the word *day* as a figure of speech. It represents the judgements which will happen on that day. In some languages this meaning must be made explicit. For example:

On that day of judgement that is coming I will
destroy them completely.

set them ablaze: The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as *set them ablaze* is different from the word which the BSB translated as “burning” in 4:1a. The expression here can be used literally to describe burning something completely, until it is only ashes. Here it is probably used as a figure of speech. It means that the people would be completely destroyed when the LORD judged them.

4:1d

says the LORD of Hosts.

- Yahweh Sabaot declares,
- Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur),

says the LORD of Hosts: The speech clause, *says the LORD of Hosts* (or “says the LORD”) occurs many times throughout the text. It emphasizes again and again that this is a direct message from the LORD. See the note on 1:2b, 1:6e, 3:5j and 3:7e. See note 1 in “Literary structure and recurring features in Malachi” in the Introduction.

Notice that in the BSB this clause occurs after the speech. This is good English style. You should place it wherever is natural in your language.

the LORD of Hosts: This special title for the LORD occurs twenty-four times in Malachi. See the note on 3:1f. See also the discussion of this term in the Key biblical terms in the book of Malachi section in the Introduction.

4:1e

“Not a root or branch will be left to them.”

- “like a plant/tree/bush that burns so completely that not a single root or branch remains.”
- “no single branch/twig, no root, will remain.”
- “so that nothing at all remains of them.”

Not a root or branch will be left to them: This expression again emphasizes complete destruction. It symbolizes this destruction by using a figure of speech. The evil-doers would be like a plant which the LORD would completely destroy, even with all of its roots and branches.

If a literal translation is not clear in your language, there are at least two other possibilities:

- Use a simile. For example:

They will be consumed like a tree—roots and all.
(NLT)

- Translate the meaning directly without the figure of speech. For example:

and there will be nothing left of them. (GNT)

Use an option which is clear and natural in your language.

General Comment on 4:1a–e

In this verse the LORD uses a word picture to express what the day of judgement will be like. The picture has at least three parts:

1. That day (or the punishments on that day) will be like a great fire in a furnace.
2. Evil people will be destroyed like stubble is destroyed in a fire.
3. They will be like a plant/tree that is completely burned up with all its roots and branches.

In some languages it may be difficult to use all of these word pictures in this verse. If that is true in your language, you may need to omit some of the details of the word picture. For example, GNT does not mention the “furnace” or “branches and roots.”

The day is coming when all proud and evil people will burn like straw. On that day they will burn up, and there will be nothing left of them.

Express the meaning in a vivid, clear and natural way in your language.

Malachi 4:2

Section 4:1–6: One day the LORD will come and judge all people

In the Hebrew text these verses are still part of chapter 3 and are numbered 3:19–24. Some English translations follow that Hebrew verse numbering, but in this book, the notes follow the more common English convention. It is recommended that you follow the numbering system of the versions used most in your area.

4:2a

“But for you who fear My name,

- But for you^(plur) who fear/revere my name,
- It will be different for you^(plur) who honor me.

But: This verse makes a contrast between the arrogant evil-doers who were mentioned in 4:1 and those who fear the LORD. In some languages it may be helpful to make that contrast explicit. For example:

But it will be different on that day for you who
revere my name.

you who fear My name: See “fear” in the note on 1:6c–d.

My name: In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “the LORD’s name” or “his name” refers to God himself or his authority. It was also used in this way in 1:6. See the note on 1:6f. GNT simply uses “me” instead of My name.

4:2b

the sun of righteousness will rise

- the sun that brings righteousness will rise
- the one who brings righteousness will rise like the sun

the sun of righteousness will rise: This is a metaphor. Although commentators and English versions differ about the interpretation here, it probably refers to the coming of the Messiah (see 3:1).

This metaphor of the sun rising indicates that, as the Messiah comes, he will bring light and will end darkness. In other words, he will bring goodness and justice and destroy evil. Many early commentators interpreted the “sun of righteousness” to refer to Christ.

Keil and Delitzsch (1950, page 468) suggest that, while it is true that it is the coming of Christ that reveals the righteousness of God, in this context it is “righteousness” (Hebrew *šədaq*) itself that is compared to the sun. These interpretations are similar, since the Lord is the one who brings righteousness. The Hebrew word has the basic idea of “conforming to a standard.” In the Bible this standard is the LORD’s and consists of what he knows is right and good. This standard is applicable both to righteous character and to justice in society.

righteousness: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as righteousness is the word *šedaqah*. It occurs frequently in the Old Testament. It is usually translated either righteousness or “justice.”

In this context it refers to the righteousness that the Messiah will bring when he comes. When he comes, he intends to cause his people to be righteous and to restore justice.

Most English versions translate *šedaqah* here as “righteousness.”

4:2c with healing in its wings,

- to heal you^(plur) with its rays.
- to heal/restore you^(plur) and protect you^(plur).
- He will heal and deliver you^(plur).

with healing in its wings: Scholars do not agree about what this figure of speech means. The wings of the sun probably refer to the sun’s rays. At the time when Malachi lived, artists often drew the sun with outstretched wings. This symbolizes power and protection.

So, in this context, Malachi used this figure of speech to refer to the LORD’s power to heal and protect his people from harm.

healing: The idea of healing here implies more than physical healing. It also implies spiritual healing that brings peace and well-being. In Jeremiah 33:6, the same word is used in a similar way.

In some languages a word like “healing” may refer only to physical healing. If that is true in your language, you may want to use an expression which could include spiritual healing, as well. For example:

restoration

well-being

General Comment on 4:2b–c

This passage uses the sun and its rays as figures of speech. Some ways to express the meaning are:

But for you who revere me, the one who brings righteousness will rise like the sun to deliver and restore you.

But for you who revere me, the one whom I send will rise to bring justice like the sun rises with healing in its rays.

4:2d and you will go out and leap like calves from the stall.

- Then you^(plur) will be like calves that leave their enclosure, running and jumping.
- And you^(plur) will go free, leaping for joy like calves do when someone releases them from their stall.

This verse part begins with the Hebrew conjunction *w*. It introduces another event which will happen when 4:2b occurs. English versions translate it as “and” or omit it. Use a connection which is natural in your language.

you: That is, you who fear my name. See the note on 4:2a.

will go out and leap like calves from the stall: This compares the people to calves which jump playfully when their owners release them from confinement. The emphasis is on the people’s joy and freedom. It is not on the place they will leave or go to.

The LORD was implying that on the day when he comes to bring justice/righteousness, he will free his people from all that oppresses them. Some ways to translate this are:

And you will go free, leaping with joy like calves let out to pasture. (NLT)

and you will skip about like calves released from the stall. (NET)

the stall: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as the stall literally means “tying place.” It refers to the place where calves were kept and fattened. This Hebrew expression for “stall-fed calves” occurs only three other times in the Hebrew Bible: 1 Samuel 28:24, Jeremiah 46:21 and Amos 6:4. This probably implies that the calves were well fed and healthy. For example:

You will jump around, like well-fed calves. (NCV)

However most English versions omit this implication. Instead they focus on the calves' freedom from the stall or from the place where they have been tied. For example:

You will be as free and happy as calves let out of a stall. (GNT)

Express this freedom in a natural way in your language.

Malachi 4:3

Section 4:1–6: One day the LORD will come and judge all people

In the Hebrew text these verses are still part of chapter 3 and are numbered 3:19–24. Some English translations follow that Hebrew verse numbering, but in this book, the notes follow the more common English convention. It is recommended that you follow the numbering system of the versions used most in your area.

4:3a

Then you will trample the wicked,

- You^(plur) will have victory over those who do evil
- Then you^(plur) will crush the wicked people,

Then: The word Then in the BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction w-. Here it introduces another event which will happen for the LORD's people on the day when he comes. Many English versions translate it as "and" or "then" or omit it. Others use a time phrase. For example:

On the day when I act, you will overcome the wicked. (GNT)

Use the option that is most natural in your language for this context.

you will trample the wicked: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as you will trample the wicked literally means that the righteous people will walk on those who are wicked. They will press or crush them with their feet. This is a symbol which may refer to two different customs of that time:

1. When people made wine, they walked on the grapes, crushing them with their feet in a "winepress." In the Bible, this process is used as a symbol for God's judgement. For example: "the winepress of the wrath of God" (Revelation 14:19).

2. When people conquered their enemies, they often made the enemies lie down so that they could put their feet on the enemies' necks. That was a symbol of complete victory.

In this verse the expression symbolizes that the LORD will give the righteous people complete victory over the wicked. There are several options for translation:

- Translate literally. For example:

you will trample those who are evil. (CEV)

- Translate the meaning of the symbol directly. For example:

you will overcome the wicked. (GNT)

- Use a simile. For example:

you will triumph over the wicked, as though you were walking on them.

Use an option which is appropriate for your language.

the wicked: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as wicked is the plural form of the same word which was used in 3:18. See the notes on 3:18a and 4:1b. In these verses the LORD referred to the same group of people, that is, those who did evil.

4:3b

for they will be ashes under the soles of your feet

- because they will be like ashes/dust that you^(plur) walk upon
- like people walk on ashes/dust and crush them under their feet

for: The Hebrew connector ki which the BSB translates as for introduces a clause which adds details to explain 4:3a. Here are some ways that English versions have translated it:

you will tread upon the wicked as if they were dust under your feet... (NLT)

Then you will crush the wicked like ashes under your feet... (NCV)

Use a natural connection in your language for this context.

they will be ashes under the soles of your feet: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as ashes can mean either "ashes" or "dust:"

1. It refers to ashes. It adds to the idea of 4:1, which states that evildoers will be completely burnt. Then the righteous will trample on their ashes. In that way they participate symbolically in their punishment. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, NASB, KJV, CEV, REB, NCV, GW, NET)
2. It refers to dust. It symbolizes the complete humiliation and defeat of the wicked. (GNT, NLT, NJPS)

Either option is acceptable, and you should use the one that communicates best in your language.

The Hebrew expression which the BSB translates as they will be ashes under the soles of your feet is a metaphor. Here are some translation possibilities:

- Translate literally. For example:

they will be ashes under the soles of your feet.
(NIV)

- Use a simile without stating its meaning. For example:

for they will be like ashes under the soles of your feet. (NET)

- Translate the meaning of the symbol and then use a simile. For example:

You will triumph over them as completely as though they were ashes under your feet.

Be sure to use an option which will connect naturally with your translation of 4:3a.

under the soles of your feet: This reference to a specific part of the foot makes the word picture more vivid in Hebrew. In some languages it may be more natural to make the reference general. For example:

like ashes under your feet. (NCV)

4:3c

on the day I am preparing,”

- on the day when I will act to judge people.”

on the day I am preparing: This is the same phrase as in 3:17c. Try to translate it in the same way here.

4:3d

says the LORD of Hosts.

- These are the words of Yahweh Sabaot.
- Yahweh Sabaot has spoken.
- This is what Yahweh Sabaot says to you^(plur).

says the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

the LORD of Hosts: See the note on 3:1f.

General Comment on 4:3a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to re-order some of the information in this verse. For example:

^{3c}When I come to bring justice, ^{3a}you will trample those who are evil, ^{3b}as though they were ashes under your feet. ^{3d}I, the Lord All-Powerful, have spoken! (CEV)

Malachi 4:4

Section 4:1–6: One day the LORD will come and judge all people

In the Hebrew text these verses are still part of chapter 3 and are numbered 3:19–24. Some English translations follow that Hebrew verse numbering, but in this book, the notes follow the more common English convention. It is recommended that you follow the numbering system of the versions used most in your area.

4:4a

“Remember the law of My servant Moses,

- ¶ “Remember^(plur) the laws that I commanded Moses my servant to give to you^(plur).
- ¶ “Do not forget^(plur) the laws that I gave you^(plur) through Moses my servant long ago.

The LORD continued to speak here. Since this verse begins a new paragraph, it may be helpful in some languages to repeat the speech clause from 4:3d. Check what you did in the similar situation at 3:6 and do the same here, if it is appropriate.

the law of My servant Moses: This means the law which the LORD gave to Moses to give to the people. This is made explicit in 4:4b. In some languages it may be more natural to make it explicit here.

My servant Moses: Moses is called the LORD’s servant because he consistently obeyed and submitted himself to the LORD. In some languages a word like “servant” may imply wrong meanings. If that is true in your language, try to express the idea of loyalty and obedience in a natural way. For example:

Moses, who faithfully obeyed me

Moses, my faithful worker.

4:4b**the statutes and ordinances I commanded him for all Israel at Horeb.**

- These laws included my rules and regulations. At Horeb I gave them to him and commanded that all the people of Israel obey them.
- At Mount Horeb I commanded him to tell all Israel to obey these laws and decrees.
- When I gave them to him at Mount Sinai, I told him to command all the people of Israel to obey them.

statutes: The Hebrew word *hoq* which the BSB translates statutes refers to the laws which the LORD gave to the people of Israel.

ordinances: The Hebrew word *mišpaṭ* which the BSB translates as ordinances refers to the decisions the LORD made when he judged people. He decided what was right to do in particular cases, and those decisions continued to apply for all future cases of that type. This has been translated in various ways by English versions. For example:

precepts (REB)

regulations (NLT)

commands (GNT)

all Israel: This refers to all the people of Israel.

Horeb: This is an alternative name for Mount Sinai, where the LORD gave his law to Moses.

General Comment on 4:4b

Although the terms “statutes” and “ordinances” are not always exact synonyms, here they do function as synonyms. They both refer to the laws the LORD gave to Moses. Redditt, page 185. In some languages it may be necessary to translate these two terms with only one expression. For example:

When I gave these commands to him at Mount Sinai, I ordered all the people of Israel to obey them.

Malachi 4:5**Section 4:1–6: One day the LORD will come and judge all people**

In the Hebrew text these verses are still part of chapter 3 and are numbered 3:19–24. Some English translations follow that Hebrew verse numbering, but in this book, the notes follow the more common Eng-

lish convention. It is recommended that you follow the numbering system of the versions used most in your area.

4:5a**Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet**

- הִשְׁמַעְתִּי “Listen^(plur). I Yahweh will certainly send the prophet Elijah to you^(plur)

Behold: As in 2:3a, 3:1a, 3:1e and 4:1a, the Hebrew word *hinneh* is again used to emphasize that the things the LORD stated next would definitely happen. This meant that the people of Israel needed to immediately change the way they behaved towards him.

Some ways to signal this urgency in English are:

Listen.

Be alert.

Be watchful.

I will send you Elijah the prophet: Although this mentions Elijah, it is actually a prophecy about John the Baptist (see Matthew 11:13–14). He was the messenger whose coming had already been predicted in Malachi 3:1. He would be like Elijah.

Elijah the prophet: Elijah was a well-known prophet in Israel. He lived a long time before Malachi. He never died but was taken up into heaven in a whirlwind. The people of Israel expected that he would return to the earth one day. See 1 Kings chapters 17–19, 1 Kings chapter 21; 2 Kings chapters 1 and 2, especially 2 Kings 2:1–11.

4:5b**before the coming of the great and awesome Day of the LORD.**

- before that dreadful and awesome day when all people will be judged, the day of Yahweh.
- He will come before that great day when I Yahweh will come to judge people, the day that people should fear,
- before that awesome day when I Yahweh will come and my judging them will terrify them.

the great and awesome Day of the LORD: This is the day which other prophets referred to simply as “the day of the LORD.” “The Day of the Lord, which (the prophets) announce as the day of judgement, commenced with the appearance on earth of Christ... and Christ himself declared that he had come into the world for judgement (John 9:39)...the judgement

of separating the believing from the ungodly, to give eternal life to those who believe on His name, and to bring death and condemnation to unbelievers” (Keil and Delitzsch, page 474). For example, see Amos 5:18, 5:20; Joel 1:15, 2:1, 3:14; Isaiah 13:6, 13:9; Zephaniah 1:7.

Elsewhere in Malachi, this same day has been referred to in other ways. For example: “the day of His coming” (3:2), “the day” (4:1), “the day is coming” (4:1), “the day I am preparing” (4:3).

In this verse the LORD himself is speaking. In some languages it may be necessary to use a first person pronoun to indicate this. For example:

the day when I, the LORD, will judge.

great: This day is described as great because it is uniquely important. It is the day when the LORD will finally judge all people.

awesome: The day is described as awesome because it will cause terror and intense fear in human beings. Other words which could be used in English are “dreadful,” “terrifying,” or “fearsome.”

Malachi 4:6

Section 4:1–6: One day the LORD will come and judge all people

In the Hebrew text these verses are still part of chapter 3 and are numbered 3:19–24. Some English translations follow that Hebrew verse numbering, but in this book, the notes follow the more common English convention. It is recommended that you follow the numbering system of the versions used most in your area.

4:6a

And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children,

- He will cause fathers to reconcile with their children,

And: The word And in the BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction *w-*. Here it introduces what the person who will be like Elijah will do when he comes. Many English versions omit the word. Use what is natural in your language here.

he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children: This means that the one who will be like Elijah will help fathers reconcile with their children. Fathers will have feelings of love for their children again.

4:6b

and the hearts of the children to their fathers.

- and he will cause children to reconcile with their fathers.

and the hearts of the children to their fathers:

This clause repeats the main idea of 4:6a from the children’s point of view. Some of the information is implied. The full idea is: “and he will turn the hearts of children to their fathers also” In some languages it may be necessary to repeat the implied information here. For example:

He will help fathers reconcile with their children,
and he will also help children reconcile with their fathers.

4:6c

Otherwise, I will come and strike the land with a curse.”

- Otherwise I will come and curse/destroy your^(plur) land.”
- If they do that, I will not come and destroy your^(plur) land with a curse.”

Otherwise: The Hebrew conjunction which the BSB translates as Otherwise introduces a warning. Here are some other ways to express this in English:

lest I come and smite the land with a curse. (RSV)

so that I will not come and strike the earth with judgment. (NET)

If not, I will come and reclaim my land by destroying you. (GW)

Use a natural way to express the warning in your language.

strike the land with a curse: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as curse refers to the most severe type of curse among the Hebrews. This is a different Hebrew word than the one that was used in 2:2 and 3:9. This word means that the person or thing which is cursed must be totally destroyed. In this verse, the LORD indicated that if people did not change as described in 4:6a–b, he would totally destroy the land of Israel.

In some languages this meaning must be made explicit. For example:

otherwise I would have to come and destroy your country. (GNT)

strike: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as strike can be translated as “smite,” “destroy,” or “punish.”

the land: This refers to the land of Israel.